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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

PM's address to the nation

Operational approach of government will be changed: Prime Minister

Govt's focus now on game-changing hydropower projects

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 26

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has announced to change operational approach of the government.

In his address to the nation on the completion of one year in office on Tuesday, the Prime Minister said, "Today, in this statement, I admit to the people of the nation that the government did not fail, but the outcomes did not align with my aspirations."

"I declare publicly that the government's working style will now undergo a transformation," Prime Minister Prachanda said.

He further said that besides specific predetermined and unavoidable events, he would not attend external programmes. His focus would revolve around formulating new policies, drafting programmes and budgets, and addressing developmental challenges and governance issues.

"I am restructuring the Prime Minister's Office this week, this will serve as a signal and a message for the entire state," he stated.

Prime Minister Prachanda has claimed that the 2080s will mark a decade of rapid development.

Prime Minister Prachanda noted that the development initiatives would be implemented in a manner that the citizens can realise their impact. He further mentioned, "This year, a total of 776.61 kilometres of blacktopped roads and 587.5 kilometres of graveled roads have been successfully constructed."

During this period, 181.29 km of new track has been opened, he said, adding, "An additional 162,000 safe houses have been constructed and provided to the beneficiaries."

While this figure indicates progress compared to previous years, I am not satisfied with the outcomes, he added.

He informed that he was discussing policy and practice to ensure a minimum of two shifts in infrastructure development, aiming to align it as closely as possible to the 'barracks model'.

He said that necessary initiatives would be taken to increase production by augmenting exports.

This year, there's a 2.7 percentage point decrease in the consumer price growth rate compared to last year, he said, adding enhancing government policy and administrative capability is now his priority to further lower the inflation rate and make people realise the change. He also announced to expand the scope of health insurance.

Stating that the government was committed to ensuring effective implementation of Health Insurance Act, he pledged to enhance current insurance coverage and integrate all free programmes, excluding the fundamental ones, into a unified health insurance framework.

He further said that significant success was achieved in fostering trust in democracy by dismantling the VIP culture. Stating that previously a 'VIP culture' prevailed where high-profile individuals seemed untouchable by the law, he said, following the government's extensive investigation and action, even top-ranking officials, once deemed beyond law's reach, are now being held accountable.

Furthermore, the Prime Minister announced that political appointments in universities would come to an end and a merit-based approach would be adopted.

"Top-level meetings will now convene with the aim of enhancing universities, shaping a unified national perspective on foreign policy, fostering job creation, and enhancing the nation's image for investment, rather than solely focusing on power distribution," he added.

Qualified Nepalis residing anywhere in the world can aspire to become the Vice-Chancellor by presenting a transparent and convincing plan for university reform, he added.

"Meritocracy will now start and Tribhuvan University will be the point of departure," he added.

Prime Minister Prachanda has said that he is determined to complete the rest of the peace process with consensus.

Terming Nepal's peace process 'unique and exemplary' for the world, he stated that it has gained recognition at the international stage. "However, some tasks of the process remain to be completed. Now, I am determined to complete the rest of the peace process with consensus," he said in his address to the nation on Tuesday.

PM Prachanda said that during his foreign visits as the Prime Minister, he clearly stated the priorities, interests and issues of mutual cooperation of Nepal with the concerned countries.

"A strong and balanced relationship has been maintained with India and China. The cooperation and support of these neighbouring countries has increased in Nepal's development efforts. At the World Food Conference held in Rome, Italy, Nepal's presentation on food security and solving the problems of underdeveloped countries has drawn the world's attention," he said.

Likewise, the content presented by Nepal in the General Assembly of the United Nations and its other meetings has received international attention. According to him, the United Nations Secretary General's visit to Nepal at his invitation and Nepal's presentation at the Climate Change Conference held in Dubai last month, 'COP-28', were effective.

Similarly, Tatopani-Khasa, Rasuwa-Kerung, Hilsa-Purang and Korala border point of Mustang, which have been closed for a long time, have been opened for bilateral trade. "I raised the issue of tri-national connectivity for the second time when I was the Prime Minister and announced to build the road corridor to connect China and India. Now the work of the Mahakali Corridor is moving at a fast pace. The budget has been assured for the Dipayal-Khutia road connecting Taklakot in Tibet," said PM Prachanda.

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Meanwhile, he also expressed his commitment to prove wrong the statement that the water of Melamchi will not come to Kathmandu, and said that he is working with a compact plan of 28 days with the target of delivering 170 million litres of water a day to the water treatment plants at Sundarijal within a month.

PM Prachanda also said that the minimum wage of workers in the country has been increased to Rs. 17,350. More than 950,000 people who have gone for foreign employment or are self-employed abroad, are in the informal sector or are self-employed within the country have been included in the contribution-based social security scheme.

Similarly, PM Prachanda said that the government's diligence in search and rescue operations in the aftermath of the Jajarkot earthquake has increased the trust of the people towards the state. The government has decided to provide Rs. 50,000 per family for the construction of temporary housing for the families whose houses have been damaged in the earthquake and are not fit for habitation. Rs. 2.26 billion has been disbursed for the same. The temporary reconstruction work will be completed within a month, said the Prime Minister.

"Development cannot be accelerated without democracy being strong, and its benefits cannot be equally distributed among the people. Now some people have resorted to false and misleading propaganda to create resentment towards the system," said PM Prachanda while adding that their comment that the unitary rule was better than the republication system now is completely wrong.

"I am firm in favour of strengthening the provinces. Lately, I have heard and understood the dissatisfaction of the chief ministers. I assure them through this speech today that all knots of federalism are being untied very fast," he said. "It was me who convened the first meeting of the National Coordination Council."

Today, I want to bear witness to the people and also tell the ministers that we cannot afford to fail. I am in no condition and mood to forgive anyone for poor performance, stated PM Prachanda. "If I cannot create positive change and hope in the country, there is no need for me to hold the position," he said.

He also said that he would continue to strive for dialogue and understanding with the main opposition and other political parties for the implementation of the important issues related to the execution of the constitution, and for cooperation on other issues of national importance to complete the remaining work of the peace process.

Similarly, Prime Minister 'Prachanda' has said that the government is now focusing attention on game-changing large hydropower projects.

He said that India, Bangladesh and China are ready to become partners in our electricity trade, so the government has embarked on mega hydropower projects as a game changer.

He said that the infrastructure tax levied on petroleum products for the Budhigandaki hydropower project will be made available to the same project and there will be no dearth of resources.

The Prime Minister said that further study of the Karnali Chisapani hydropower project with a capacity of 10,800 megawatts has been started by the Nepal Electricity Authority with a goal of completing it within three years.

Likewise, study of the Mugu Karnali hydropower project of 1,902 MW capacity has been completed, Prime Minister Prachanda said, adding that he is also directly facilitating the 900 MW capacity Arun III hydropower project and the work of raising investment for the 1,063 MW Upper Arun hydropower project has reached its final stage.

Stating that about 564 megawatts of electricity will be added from additional projects undergoing testing commissioning within next two to three months, he said that power purchase agreements for 9,164 megawatts of hydropower projects have been completed with the private sector.

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PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' delivering his address to the nation on the occasion of the completion of one year of the government in Kathmandu on Tuesday.

- 2080s to be the decade of rapid development
- Announcement to widen scope of health insurance
- Peace process to be completed
- Water supply of Melamchi project to resume within a month
- Production-based subsidy system being implemented
- Tourism in thriving trend

One Year of Government Special Supplement

Today's TRN carries a supplement to mark the govt's completion of one year and its achievements.



'Nepal should benefit from neighbours' advancements'



Minister Rekha Sharma

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 26

Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma has said that Nepal should reap the benefit from the progress of neighbouring countries.

Minister Sharma made this remark while addressing the second China-Nepal Media Summit organised by the South Asia Network Television Media Group in coordination with the Chinese Embassy in Kathmandu on Tuesday.

The function was organised to mark the 10th anniversary of the Belt and Road Initiative and the 68th anniversary of the establishment of diplomatic relations between Nepal and China.

Pointing out that Nepal is happy with the economic progress made by its neighbours, Minister Sharma said that Nepal is benefiting from the development of its neighbours and it should be increased qualitatively.

"We expect important projects in Nepal to move forward with Chinese support. If projects such as the Nepal-China cross-border railway, the Kerung to Kathmandu-Lumbini railway can proceed, it could add a new dimension to Nepal's prosperity," said Minister Sharma.

Minister Sharma said that Nepal has been participating in various projects conducted by neighbouring and international communities in a way that aligns with the national interest.

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Efforts begin to reduce human-elephant conflict

BY BISHNU PRASAD POKHAREL
Damak, Dec. 26



Elephants coming from Assam, West Bengal and Mahanand Wildlife Sanctuary of India to Koshi Tappu Wildlife Reserve have been terrorising locals.

Considering these problems, efforts are now underway on both the Nepali and Indian sides to address the problems by protecting elephants, reducing human-elephant conflicts and promoting human-elephant coexistence.

The impetus to minimise human-animal conflict has started at a time when the elephants are prolonging their stay in Jhapa, causing more destruction.

Arjun Karki, ward chairman of Mechinagar Municipality-4, said that Kedar Karki, the Chief Minister of Koshi Province, has expressed interest in formulating effective practices for elephant control and risk reduction.

Chief Minister Karki has committed to implementing necessary programmes to control human-animal conflict within the province after inspecting the trespassing of elephants and rhinos.

A Rapid Response Team (RRT) has been established in Bahundangi to provide conservation awareness training to local youth regarding elephant behaviour and how they should treat the animals. A similar team has also been formed on the Indian side.

Ward chairman Karki said that an information network has been established to connect the RRTs on both sides of the border to share activities related to elephants. Surveillance is conducted at entry points based on information about the movement of elephants.

An 'early warning siren' has been installed at the Armed Police Force post to alert villagers about elephants entering the village. Residents are advised to stay indoors upon hearing the siren. Following the siren, the RRT, along with members of the Armed Police and the Nepal Police, jointly monitor the entry points.

Due to these efforts, there have been no recent casualties in Bahundangi, which is considered a heavily affected area in eastern Nepal, said Karki.

Bahundangi serves as a primary crossing point for elephants travelling between Nepal and India, causing long-term effects on the lives of residents. Karki added that elephants have damaged harvests, and stored grains, fruits, and cash crops.

To discourage elephants from easily entering the area, an electric fence has been installed at the border towards Nepal. However, elephants persistently use familial paths, damaging electric fences to access crops. He emphasised the need to address the concerns of affected communities and establish trust for fostering elephant-friendly human behaviour.

To assist the victims, the ward has decided to provide annual financial assistance of Rs. 12,000 to those affected by elephant attacks, particularly aiding the children of those who lost their parents in such incidents.

The team involved in this initiative is insured for Rs. 500,000, aiming to prevent potential losses of life and property caused by elephants entering the village despite vigilant monitoring of entry points.

Investment environment is improving: Dr. Mahat

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Narayangadh, Dec. 26

Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat has said that the investment environment in the country has been improving. Talking to journalists at Bharatpur Airport on Tuesday, Finance Minister Dr. Mahat said that the investment environment was gradually becoming favourable as the indicators of the economy were positive.

"The economy is getting back on track. The investment environment is gradually improving", he said, adding, "Somebody tried to disrupt the investment environment by showing fear to the investors, but we have managed to break it now and convey the message that the situation is comfortable."

Stating that there was a problem when there was a lot of negative publicity that there was no future in Nepal, he said that now negativity over the economic indicator had been cleared. "The illusions in the market are contrary to the economic indicators", he said.

Finance Minister Dr. Mahat urged the investors to invest without getting confused. "The stock market and real estate businesses are gradually improving. The largest number of tourists have ever entered Nepal. Now there is an adequate foreign currency reserve. Remittance inflow is still high," he said.

"There is more propaganda that nothing should be done even in such a favourable situation for investment. Against this, the private sector and civil society need to explain the reality to the public."

He informed that there was ample capital in our market and said that it was necessary to make it vibrant. "The interest rate has decreased, its effect has started to affect the banks", he said.

The latest decision of the Nepal Rastra Bank has addressed the distressed businessmen, he said, adding that this has also opened the way to create an investment-friendly environment.

Elephant festival begins

In the meantime, Finance Minister Dr. Mahat inaugurated the elephant festival that started in Sauraha, Chitwan on Tuesday. Inaugurating the festival, which was organised to promote tourism, he said that the country's tourism was now gaining momentum.

"The flow of tourists so far is a sign that the tourism business has caught the rhythm," he added, "If investment in infrastructure is centralised, new tourism potential areas will open up." Earlier, the elephant festival was held at the yard of Baghmara Community Forest, but this year it was held at the yard ear Chitrasari.

The festival will continue till Saturday. The Elephant Festival, which was organised in previous years by including elephant activities and sports, is being done with some modifications from this year.

According to Ganga Giri, president of the association, special attractions of the festival are the elephant feast, elephant beauty competition, and cultural programmes.



PHOTO: BASANTA PARAJULI

Elephant festival starts in Chitwan.

FIND AMICABLE SOLUTION TO POWER TARIFF

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 26

The Nepal Chamber of Commerce (NCC) has requested the concerned authorities to find an amicable solution to the disputes relating to the tariff arrears of the dedicated and trunk lines.

The NCC said that a difference of opinions between the Nepal Electricity Authority and industrialists regarding tariffs of the dedicated and trunk lines could affect the overall investment and business-friendly environment.

Issuing a press statement on Tuesday, the NCC said, "Its attention to the recent differences of opinion between the NEA and the businessmen has been drawn.

It is sure to affect the industry-friendly environment and investment."

It said that if the problem was not resolved immediately, it would also affect employment and revenue collection.

The Chamber has requested to form an investigation committee, including financial and technical experts, to find a solution to the problem.

Stating that both the government and the private sector have equal roles in creating an investment and business-friendly environment, the NCC drew the attention of the concerned parties to proceed with a fair solution.

The Chamber has also suggested finding an immediate solution and not to escalate the dispute further.

COLD STORE COMES INTO OPERATION IN SINGA OF BENI

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Myagdi, Dec. 26

A cold store built in Beni Municipality-4 of Myagdi has come into operation. The municipality has constructed the cold store so that the fruits and vegetables produced by the farmers can be stored and sold during the off-season.

After the construction of the cold store in the village, the compulsion to sell agricultural produce at a cheap price will come to an end. "We have brought the cold store into operation, and we have started storing oranges as a test.

After the test is successful, we will store the fruits and vegetables produced by the farmers in this area," said Ana Bahadur Khadka, ward chairman of Beni Municipality-4.

An employee has been arranged to look after the cold store. He expressed his belief that as Singa area is a pocket area for the production of fruits and vegetables, after the cold store comes into operation, it will be easy for the local farmers to store the agricultural produce harvested during the season and sell it during the off-season.

He said that they have a target to store 900 kg of oranges to test the cold store. He said that the cold store would be brought into full operation after the test became successful.

He said that the farmers would be able to earn Rs. 30 to Rs. 40 per kg by deducting the cost of selling vegetables and fruits kept in cold stores. He said that the cold store can store 30,000 kg of oranges and potatoes.

Chairman Khadka said that as cold store was equipped with modern facilities including electricity supply, and oranges will be stored next year according to its capacity.

Rajeshbabu Construction Services, Jajarkot, has completed the construction at a cost of Rs. 15.1 million although the estimated cost of the project was Rs. 18.3 million.

There was the partnership of federal, provincial and local governments to complete the project.

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Petroleum exploration reaches final stage

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Dullu (Dailekh), Dec. 26

The petroleum exploration work in the Panchkoshi area of Dailekh is nearing completion. The preparations for the final drilling have been started from the Shirasthan temple located in Bhairabi Rural Municipality-1 area where the flame is burning to Jaljele in the north-east region.

An open space of 100 by 100 metres is being prepared for the drilling, while space is being arranged for installing the machine. Dinesh Kumar Napit, chief of Petroleum Exploration Project, who is working at the construction site on behalf of the Department of Mines and Geology, said that if the machine can be installed within next month, drilling will be done down to about 4 kilometres.

He claimed that if the road infrastructure is ready and the equipment can be installed within the specified time, there will be a breakthrough within four months. Prior to this, after drilling at more than 3,000 locations within a radius of about 300 kilometers, a type of earth that sends waves through explosions was processed and the information obtained from the study of the mine storage area was ascertained.

After the acquisition of 45 ropanies of land for a total of 28 households in Jaljale located in Bhairabi Rural Municipality-1, the construction of the infrastructure has progressed. Setting up a camp and addressing the demands of the locals have also been taken together to remove the disruptions of the national pride project, which is considered to be an ambitious project that can open the door to the economic prosperity of the country.

Acting Chief District Officer Ganesh Prasad Koirala said that the work to expand the Karnali Highway has been accelerated to bring in large equipment for drilling. The equipment will be brought from China's Tianjin city to the project site. Previously, the technical team has completed seismic, geological, magneto-telluric, geochemical sampling surveys and other works.

For exploration, in 2019, an agreement was signed between the Department of Mines and Geology, Nepal government and Geological Survey Company, Chinese government for the financial and technical support of Rs. 2.40 billion for the exploration and extraction of petroleum products.

An agreement was made to complete the exploration work by 2022, but due to the COVID-19 pandemic, the work could not be completed as anticipated. Again, after the cabinet meeting on March 28, 2022 decided to extend the project by two years, further work was initiated. However, the project will proceed only by extending the period when the specified time period is about to end.

11 thousand temporary shelters built for Jajarkot quake victims

RSS
Kathmandu, Dec. 26

So far 11,336 temporary houses have been constructed for the earthquake survivors in five districts. More than 67 thousand beneficiaries have been registered in Jajarkot, Rukum West and Salyan districts of Karnali province and Bajura and Bajhang of the Sudurpaschim province until now.

The National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority (NDRRMA) said 10,118 more temporary houses are being built. NDRRMA chief executive officer Anil Pokharel said the beneficiaries have been taking the grant amount meant for building temporary shelters entering into agreement and constructing the temporary houses.

According to him, 5,202 temporary shelters have been built in Jajarkot and 5,798 in Rukum West. Similarly, 193 temporary houses have been built in Salyan, 13 in Bajhang and 130 in Bajura districts. Over Rs 2.26 billion has been allocated to the affected districts and more budget will be needed as the number of beneficiaries rises. Of this amount, Rs 1.53 billion has reached the local levels from the districts. Pokharel added that Rs 587 million 800 thousand has been transferred to the bank account of the beneficiaries verified by the local level.

There are 35,140 beneficiaries in Jajarkot followed by 23, 608 in Rukum West; 4,576 in Bajhang; 2,729 in Bajura and 1,730 in Salyan, according to the Authority. NDRRMA, Policy and Planning Division Chief Bharat Mani Pandey said grant agreement still remains to be signed with nearly 50 thousand additional beneficiaries and the signing of agreement is ongoing. It is estimated that the number of beneficiaries will reach 80 thousand and the Authority is making its preparations accordingly, Pandey added.

He said the NDRRMA is preparing to manage Rs 4.75 billion that would be required for building temporary shelters for the estimated 80 thousand beneficiaries. The November 3 earthquake with its epicenter at Ramidanda of Jajarkot affected Rukum West, Salyan, Bajhang and Bajura as well. Now the constructions of temporary shelters for the affected are going on.

Homestay comes into operation along trekking route to Chepang village

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 25

In order to bring foreign tourists to the remote hilly areas of Chitwan, Chepang homestay has been brought into operation along the trekking route.

With financial support of Sapana Village Social Impact, Sauraha, homestay has been brought into operation by the local Chepang community of Chitwan on the trekking route from Hugdikhola in Dhading to Sauraha in Chitwan.

Dhruba Giri, founder chairperson of Sapana Village Social Impact (SVSI), said that Chepang homestay has been operated in Ichchakamana-2, Tobang and Ichchakamana-1, Bharang.

He said that they have assisted the locals in operating Chepang homestay targeting the tourists who trek from Hugdikhola in Dhading under Prithivi Highway via Ichchhakamana-2 Tobang, Hattibang, Siraichuli, Bharang of Ward No. 1 and Shaktikhor of Kalika Municipality to Sauraha.

He said that SVSI will provide financial support and training to operate more homestays to increase the income level of the Chepang community. He said, "In order to improve the economic standard of the Chepang community here, we will provide financial support and training to those who are interested in operating homestay. Our plan is to train the Chepang community to maintain cleanliness and exhibit culture, religion and lifestyle of the Chepangs to tourists and their polish behaviour to welcome the tourists."

Talking to The Rising Nepal, Giri said that the trekking route and homestay have been brought into operation since Sunday on trial and more homestays in the Chepang villages along the trekking route will be added gradually.



PHOTO: TRN

Foreigners take photo in front of Tilu Chepang's homestay at Tobang, Ichchhakamana Rural Municiplaity-2.

Marius Appelman, owner of Dutch Travel Company, Riksja Travels, inaugurated the homestay run by local Tilu Chepang and his family of Ichchhakamana Rural Municiplaity-2, Tobang recently.

He said that he is very happy to learn about the culture and lifestyle of the Chepang community. He expressed his belief that this trekking route has the potential to become one of the best in Nepal.

"This trekking route has the potential to become one of the best in Nepal. We, the visitors, can be aware about the culture and lifestyle of the Chepang community," he said.

Meanwhile, homestay director Tilu Chepang thanked Sapana Village Social Impact, Sapana Village Lodge and Riksja Travels for fulfilling his dream to run a homestay.

Tilu said, "Today I am very happy. I had a desire to operate a homestay in the village to promote tourism and local resources in Chepang Hills. With the help of Sapana Village, my dream has come true today."

Tilu and his family are running a beautiful homestay with two comfortable and clean rooms. The SVSI visited Marius Appleman, Dutch Travel Company, Riksja Travels, last year to study the feasibility of this trekking route.

President Giri said that this route spans two nights and three days. Sapana Village Lodge offers Chepang Hills trekking and homestay packages. He said that this trekking route is being promoted with the aim of bringing in tourists from the Netherlands, Germany, UK, France and other countries.

He said that the income level of the Chepang community here will increase as the flow of tourists increases. The SVSI is conducting various programmes, including education and health, for the upliftment of Chepang community in Chitwan.



PHOTO: NISHA RAI

Kirat people in Dharan drawing rally and performing an exotic Sakela dance to celebrate the Udhauli Festival in Dharan, Tuesday.

'Timely development of Marxism is a challenge'

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 26

Prime Minister and Chairman of CPN (Maoist Centre) Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that Marxism is a philosophy centred on the specific analysis of real situations.

Addressing a gathering during the commemoration of the 131st 'Mao Day' at the party's central office in Paris Danda on Tuesday morning, he said the major challenge facing the communist movement today is the continuous evolution of ideas to suit the contemporary needs, he said.

He underscored the necessity of formulating ideas that align with the continuously changing circumstances.

"Today's national and international scenarios differ from Mao's era. Since Mao's time, there has been a total transformation in the global landscape, notably in the sector of information technology," he remarked.

"Imperialism continues to persist by adopting new strategies and tactics. As Marxists, we have not been able to transform ourselves in accordance with the specific circumstances. This stands as the primary challenge we face today," he added.

Stating that honouring Mao's legacy also involves contemplating ideas and revolution with an original perspective, he said, adding, "He has made fundamental contributions to all three basic components of Marxism, pioneering its most creative developments.

"That's the path from which we learn. We must avoid falling into any mechanistic or blind approaches. This direction aligns with the synthesised course of action outlined in the 8th general convention of the party," he said.

Prime Minister Prachanda stressed that the foundation of socialism should be prepared taking the path of social justice, good governance and prosperity.

"We have given high priority to social justice, good governance and prosperity, which reflects our commitment to laying the groundwork for socialism. It is imperative that we make progress based on these principles," he added.

Chairman Prachanda said following the completion of the Maoist special transformation campaign, the party planned to embark on another campaign engaging with the people.

He mentioned, "As the four-month campaign concludes on January 1, our next step involves direct engagement with the people to exchange ideas through discussions. Consequently, we will launch another campaign specifically centred around fostering and exchanging ideas."

MoCIT working to upgrade IT system

BY SRIJANA RAI (RSS)
Kathmandu, Dec. 26

The Ministry of Communications and Information Technology (MoCIT) has been enforcing laws and policies aligning the annual programmes, goals and periodic plans. The ministry has informed that some bases of policy implementation could be observed over the year.

Nepal ranks 151 on the E-governance Development Index, while the MoCIT is effortful in preparing the telecommunication infrastructures, people's access to IT for public service and capacity building of relevant workforce. The MoCIT has been working actively to adopt and improve the Integrated Office Management System and correct website template, increase threat surveillance through monitoring of IT system, ensure better communication and connection via group SMS, connect people to the Nagarik App, promote software and hardware vetting, data recovery and cloud computing.

Ministry spokesperson Netra Subedi informed, "In the past year, some new initiatives were launched, while some were near completion." However, he admitted that some were not enforced as expected.

According to him, there are hindrances on structural and practical levels, which could be foiled via coordination and confidence. The expansion of optical fiber has reached 15,000 km by mid-November from 12,230 km in mid-January.

Similarly, the expansion of fixed broadband has upped by 4 per cent and internet consumers' density witnessed a 3 per cent rise. Now, the number of government offices integrated with the Nagarik App has reached 62 from 53. The mobile broadband expansion has reached 94.88 per cent, while radio's access is 92 per cent.

Moreover, the FTTH service is now available in 73 districts and the 4G/LTE service reached 67 per cent. A total of 39 government offices are enforcing GIOM.

On the policy and law fronts, the printing bill and public service broadcasting bill are under consideration at the parliamentary committee, while the Council of Ministers has approved the process of formulation of Nepal Media Council Bill, National Mass Communications Bill, and the bill relating to regulation and management of social networks.

The National Cyber Security Policy, 2080 has come into operation, and the Radio Frequency Policy of Telecommunications Service, 2080 has been endorsed.

As per the ministry, NTA's policy on the use of information technology, 2080 has been approved, while the draft of the National Advertisement Policy, 2080

The Advertisement Regulation, 2080 has been amended, while the postal office regulation was presented to the Council of Ministers. Concept paper on AI Moreover, the Directive on Management of the Use of Social Networks, 2080 is approved. The MoCIT also shared the information that it was working on a concept paper on artificial intelligence. "A concept paper on AI is being prepared with the consultation of experts," spokesperson Subedi informed RSS. The IT division under the ministry is coordinating on 'Digital Nepal Framework'. The Framework is being updated, while 'Digital Nepal Acceleration Project' is being implemented under the support of the World Bank.

The social networks unit at the ministry is devoted to the smooth operation and regulation of social networks as per the Directive.

Digital signature, development and standard of IT, connecting service delivery to IT, and incorporation of fundamental issues of cyber safety and data security are being finalised under the IT bill.

Even a virtual interaction named 'meet your minister' is in operation. Efforts are underway to receive complaints of indifference to concern by the platform owners online. "Serious homework is on to reduce the digital divide," Subedi said, adding, "The ministry is aware of all-out efforts to fend off cyber-attacks and build cyber hygiene". The cyber security monitoring centre is run round the clock now.

JOURNALIST SILWAL APPOINTED EXPERT AT PASHUPATI TRUST

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 26

The Pashupati Area Development Trust has appointed journalist Ashok Silwal, who is also a Langtang goodwill ambassador, as a Pashupati expert.

Silwal is the author of books such as Kalam, Lekhak Duniya, Sri Lanka Smriti and others.

> Silwal is the author of books such as Kalam, Lekhak Duniya, Sri Lanka Smriti and others.

He is also an advisor to the Village Tourism Promotion Forum Nepal.

He made two documentaries titled 'People Returning' and 'Waking and Walking' as the first journalist to reach Langtang on foot after the devastating earthquake of 2015.

"I am excited to have an opportunity to contribute to Pashupati, the greatest centre of spirituality and faith in Nepal," said Silwal after his appointment on Tuesday.

Tents distributed to Jajarkot quake victims

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 26

Minister for Women, Children, and Senior Citizens, Surendra Raj Acharya handed over the tents to the earthquake victims of Rawat Gaun in Bheri Municipality-1 in Jajarkot.

The tents were provided by the European Union to Save the Children for distribution.

Distributing the tents on Monday, Minister Acharya said the tents would protect the quake victims from the winter cold.

Several people in Rukum West and Jajarkot were rendered homeless when a 6.4 earthquake jolted the two districts on November 3.

At the handover event, Minister Acharya said, "The government is committed to ensuring the protection, safety, and rehabilitation of communities affected by the earthquake.

It is closely collaborating with organisations like Save the Children to effectively distribute life-saving aid to the affected communities, with a particular focus on women, children, pregnant and lactating mothers."

He also interacted with lactating and pregnant mothers who were living under the tents and expressed the government's commitment to allocate more resources to support earthquake victims.

Tara Chettry, Acting Country Director of Save the Children, said, "The collaboration among the government and local development partners has enabled us to promptly reach out to the most affected communities, providing them with immediate life-saving support."

We are confident that the winterisation tents funded by the EU will save the lives of many children, women, and the elderly facing extreme cold, Chettry said.

Since the earthquake, 32 people, including three children, have succumbed to extreme cold.

On December 8, the European Union provided Save the Children with 800 winterisation tents to distribute in earthquake-impacted areas of Jajarkot and Rukum West.

These tents are fire-retardant, waterproof, equipped with stoves, and offer a total living area of 23 square meters, designed to withstand harsh winter conditions.

As part of post-earthquake humanitarian programmes, Save the Children has supported earthquake-affected communities with temporary shelters, psychosocial support, temporary learning centres for children, winterisation tents, dignity and hygiene kits, and child-friendly spaces to protect vulnerable children, women, and communities most in need.

Development cannot take pace without security: IGP

BY DIL BAHADUR SINGH
Silgadhi (Doti), Dec. 26

Inspector General of Police (IGP) of Nepal Police Basanta Bahadur Kunwar has said that development in the country will not take the pace without ensuring security. Inaugurating the newly constructed District Police Office in Silgadhi of Doti district on Tuesday, IGP Kunwar said that the role of Nepal Police was important to manage security in the country.

The development works targeted by the state could move ahead only in a fear-free environment, he said.

IGP Kunwar further said, "It is necessary for the local government, government and non-government sectors, including the stakeholders to work together for peace and security.

Nepal Police has a concept that it should be a citizen-friendly security force by promoting internal reforms as a campaign.

In the programme, Sudurpaschim Province Police Chief Deputy Inspector General of Police Bharat Bahadur Bohara expressed his belief that the morale of the police personnel would be high when they delivered services from safe office buildings. In the past, the Doti Police was providing services from the old and unsafe buildings.

> Inaugurating the newly constructed District Police Office in Silgadhi of Doti district on Tuesday, IGP Kunwar said that the role of Nepal Police was important to manage security in the country.

The buildings were constructed under the regular budget of the government.

The office building, residences for office chief and senior officers, detention room, barrack building, kitchen and other buildings were inaugurated on the District Police Officer premises of Doti.

According to the District Police Office Doti, Rs. 100.8 million was spent to construct the buildings.

Dumping site makes life of Musikot locals difficult

BY RAJU LAMICHHANE
Rukum West, Dec. 26

The stench and pollution from the dumping site at Satipole, Musikot Municipality-2, has made life very difficult for people living in the nearby areas.

Residents of Purundanda, Simkhola, Baripole, Sisnekhola and other surrounding communities have to hold their nose even when inside their houses. Local Tilak Khadka said that he and his neighbours were neither able to eat nor sleep.

Satipole gets garbage from Khalanga, Serigaun, Bagbazaar and Patukhola. Every few days, this waste is burnt. This releases toxic smoke that, Khadka worried, would harm people's health.

Another local Bishnu Khadka expressed anger at the local government and said that its inaction and ignorance had caused the present situation. "This indifference by the Musikot Municipality is damaging both our health and the environment," he protested.

Land acquired for parking, turned into dumping site

People told The Rising Nepal that the municipality tricked them into giving their land for the dumping site. Dil Bahadur Sarki, one of the persons who gave their land, informed that the local representatives promised to use the land to build a jeep park. "But they constructed a landfill instead."



PHOTO: RAJU LAMICHHANE/TRN

Residents of Purundanda, Simkhola, Baripole, Sisnekhola and other surrounding communities have to hold their nose even when inside their houses.

"They used our land to poison us," he expressed with sadness.

Meanwhile, Musikot Municipality claimed that Satipole was only a temporary landfill site and that more sustainable plans were being devised to manage solid waste. Mayor Mahendra KC also said that unidentified people, and not the municipality, were setting fire to the garbage. "We do not burn the accumulated rubbish, we bury it," he clarified. Permanent landfill under construction

Mayor KC informed that a permanent dumping site was being constructed at Nepane, Musikot-1, at a cost of Rs. 10 million.

He said that the municipality would begin throwing waste there from this fiscal year. However, Nepane locals are protesting the landfill and have asked the local government to not endanger their well-being by turning their neighbourhood into the city's dumping site.

NEWS BRIEF

Child dies falling into septic tank

Sarlahi: A child died after he fell into a septic tank in Ward No. 8 of Ishwarpur Municipality in Sarlahi district. According to police, Sohan Raut, the two-and-a-half-year-old son of Kamal Raut, drowned in the septic tank at the house of neighbour Man Bahadur Karki. The tank was covered by tin sheets.

"The child was rescued and rushed to Amrit Health Care in Bayalbas, but was pronounced dead upon arrival," said Man Prasad Shrestha, Inspector of Keshargunj Area Police.

Elderly dies of suffocation

Kathmandu: An elderly died of suffocation in Namobuddha Municipality of Kavrepalanchowk district.

Karma Gyalbo Lama, 82, and his wife were found unconscious inside their house Tuesday morning. Karma died during treatment at Dhulikhel Hospital where his wife is receiving medical care.

Police informed that the couple had slept after turning on a heater and making fire inside their room. They also closed the doors and windows preventing proper air circulation, leading to suffocation.

Further investigation is said to be underway.

(TRN)

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

No legacy is so rich as honesty.
- William Shakespeare

EDITORIAL

Conclude TRC Process

With the top leaders of three major political parties deciding to pass a Bill on Commission on Investigation of Enforced Disappeared Persons, Truth and Reconciliation Commission (TRC) from the upcoming winter session of the Federal Parliament, a hope for the settlement of tricky part of peace process has been raised. Chiefs of three parties had held their meeting at the residence of Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda on Monday. It will be a real breakthrough if the parties are able to endorse the Bill having the provisions of credible mechanism to conclude the remaining process of the TRC, an integral part of the Comprehensive Peace Agreement (CPA) signed between the then government and CPN-Maoist in 2006.

Earlier, the political parties were just able to establish these two commissions but they lack the mandate and capacity to give a logical conclusion to the peace process in the spirit of the CPA. The historic agreement has paved the way for the enactment of the Interim Constitution, formation of the Constituent Assembly, promulgation of the federal democratic and republican constitution. The reconciliation process is yet to yield positive results so that the conflict victims get the justice. Those victimised by both the state's security agencies and former Maoist rebels have been calling for ensuring justice to them as the TJ process was inordinately delayed owing to the parties' divergent stances on the content of the Bill. The parties require setting aside of their differences and partisan interests when it comes to sorting out the controversial provisions of the proposed Bill.

The TRC is also linked with correcting the past mistakes and negating violence in the future so as to promote a civilised and rule-governed society. Logical conclusion of TRC process not only helps uphold the rule of law but also boosts the dignity of the country in the eyes of international community. Just formation and continuation of TRC-related commissions is not enough. There should be meaningful debate on the key issues and creation of widely accepted modality for the swift and trustworthy reconciliation.

It is imperative to forge consensus among the political parties to this end. The process shall be more reliable if the issues relating to victim's concerns and international standards are addressed in terms of principles and procedures. The parties should not sidestep these vital matters. They should develop minimum common understanding, no matter whether they are in the government or in the opposition. Nepal's peace process has been dubbed as homegrown and successful model. Barring the TJ process, the parties have resolved other contentious issues such the management of arms, reparation to the combatants and their integration and rehabilitation. This has enhanced nation's image and credibility.

As Martin Luther King had said, in 1963, that injustice anywhere is a threat to justice everywhere, the political parties should show prudence and flexibility to end the TRC process at the earliest possible, bearing in mind that justice should finally prevail. The lawmakers have the responsibility to pore over and revise the Bills, if necessary, before endorsing it in the upcoming session of the parliament. The issue of TRC should not be an albatross around the neck of the parties who were the part of the decade-long insurgency. All parties should be serious about delivering justice to the victims without further delay.

Achieve New Year Resolves

DIXYA POUDEL

One of the wonders of human nature is adaptability to change, even if it might be one of the hardest things. Although it may seem like a child's personality is set quite unwaveringly by the time he or she becomes an adult, according to neuroscience, human minds are plastic in nature regardless of their age. As such, being plastic refers to the mind's ability to stretch, rewire and reconfigure, according to changing circumstances. It is thus never too late to pursue one's dreams, especially on the verge of a New Year which comes with the promise of a better future.

Only a pessimist who is always decrying a half-empty cup is immune to the New Year celebrations, festivities, and a promise of new beginnings. Often such person tends to focus on the negative side of things, thwarting positive sides into the periphery. Casting aside negativity, New Year's Day instead signals new resolutions for a positive change in life. And fitness mantra tops the list of New Year resolutions for most people worldwide. Then come mental health, career, academic and relationship goals. However, although it is great to be enthusiastic over such goals, it is necessary to be practical, realistic, and sensible about them.

Instead of crash dieting, which can be unhealthy, let's make it a resolution to eat healthy while also hydrating enough this year. No more love handles that make us look frumpy in cute dresses. Instead, let's allocate time for fitness and exercise each day. It could mean walking or jogging around the neighbourhood park for half an hour each day and adhering to it, come rain or shine. Then there are work and education aspirations as well which require a good brain health. And we should never underestimate the impact of brain health as it colours each and every aspect of our lives significantly.

Meanwhile, it could also help to focus on relationships and social resolutions so as to be a loving and supportive spouse, offspring, sibling, relation and so on. Being kind to strangers too is an added attribute. These are just a few examples of resolutions that one could set. According to psychology, in order to achieve our resolutions, it is important to ensure that they align with our biogenic, sociogenic, and idiogenic nature. Biogenic refers to the inherent personality of a person shaped by biology, sociogenic is about the social environment that shapes a person, and idiogenic involves personal elements that in turn affect an individual.

By understanding one's personality, environment, and individualistic milieu, it is possible to ensure not just success in life but also happiness and fulfillment. Who are we? What are our inherent natures and purpose? Where do we fall on the range of extroversion, neuroticism, conscientiousness, openness, and agreeableness? These five factors drive the personality of a person and are widely used in psychology. By aligning our resolutions with our inner values, personality, and external environment, it is quite possible to fulfill them. New Year clocks in each year with a reminder of ticking time of one's precious life. With this reminder in mind, let's set resolutions with an optimistic and practical outlook. Let's also be grateful for New Year 2024 that grants us 365 more days to be a better person.

Debates On Kissinger's Legacy



Dinesh Bhattarai

Obituaries and commentaries published after the death of former United States Secretary of State and National Security Adviser Henry Alfred Kissinger (1923-2023) described him as "the master of events" with a long journey of exemplary career. He was the "Cold War's most powerful Secretary of State and a peerless elder statesman," with a complex legacy. There are both critics and admirers describing him as "one of the most controversial and influential foreign policy thinkers and practitioners of the past 50 years." They are divided on whether he was a "towering statesman or war criminal?"

Kissinger came to the US in 1938, to escape Hitler's Germany. He was back in Germany serving the US Army after World War II. He attended Harvard University, obtained his Ph.D. and taught from 1954-1969. His writings on nuclear warfare and foreign policy went to be noticed by President Dwight Eisenhower, Vice-President Richard Nixon and New York Governor Nelson Rockefeller. He was foreign policy adviser during the Rockefeller presidential campaign in 1960, 1964 and 1968. After Nixon was elected as the president of the United States in 1967, Kissinger was appointed as his National Security Adviser and Secretary of State, serving simultaneously. Kissinger and Vietnamese leader Le Duc Tho were jointly awarded the Nobel Peace Prize in 1973. Tho declined, Kissinger humbly accepted the honor.

Whether in or out of office, Kissinger was always in "the spotlight of global geopolitics." He played important roles in three big transformations: withdrawal from Vietnam, the opening to China and shaping American foreign policy towards the Soviet Union. In July 1971, Kissinger's secret visit to Beijing laid the ground work for President Nixon's historic trip to China in 1972, paving way for reforms and opening. Kissinger told his Chinese host Premier Zhou Enlai, "Reality has brought us together and we believe that reality will shape our future."

Renowned strategist

China held Kissinger in high esteem, and described him as best known in China and all over the world for diplomacy to seek common ground while reserving differences. In his condolence message sent to President Biden, Chinese President Xi Jinping called Kissinger "a world-renowned strategist." Prominent Chinese scholars praised Kissinger for his use of "realism to the extreme in virtuous and rational way and his ability "to transcend differences with other countries without strong political and ideological biases." China wanted Kissinger to play a role in Xi-Biden meeting in San Francisco in September, but he was too frail.

Before death, Nixon reportedly regretted with his speechwriter creating a "Frankenstein," with Kissinger. Kissinger continued to promote China until his last days, as evidenced by his visit at the age of 100. Today's reality is US-China relationship is not only "shaping the future," but also shaking the world. After Nixon's resignation amid the Watergate scandal, Kissinger held the same two positions for President Gerald Ford. In 1975, Kissinger relinquished the National Security job at President's suggestion, coinciding with Congress becoming assertive in foreign policy, legislating issues including arms control, human rights, and foreign military issues.

Kissinger's critics blamed him for his policies in support of repressive regimes, citing support to Chilean general August Pinochet, who overthrew democratically elected socialist President Salvador Allende. Kissinger brushed aside State Department officials' pleas to hold Pinochet accountable for his human rights abuses. Kissinger is criticized for his support of "massive bombing campaign of Cambodia" that led to its destabilization, paving the way for the Khmer Rouge to move into the vacuum and killing 2 million people - a quarter of country's population. US's green signal to President Suharto was said to be "fundamental to Indonesia's invasion and occupation," of East Timor.

> He was a practitioner of "Realpolitik" which requires doing unpleasant things with unpleasant people. To Kissinger, The Economist writes: "principles often took a back seat to national interests."

Garry J. Bass, author of "The Blood Telegram, Nixon, Kissinger and a Forgotten Genocide" highlights Kissinger's indifference to "the worst atrocities" in the then East Pakistan (now Bangladesh) under Pakistani military ruler Yahya Khan, resulting in the loss of millions of civilian lives. Kissinger is said to have written back to diplomatic personnel, "do not squeeze Yahya at this time." Pakistan was an important American client during the Cold War, and helped get Kissinger into China July 1971. He justified these actions on the basis of national security interests. He was a practitioner of "Realpolitik" which requires doing unpleasant things with unpleasant people. To Kissinger, The Economist writes: "principles often took a back seat to national interests."

Though Kissinger retired from the office with Jimmy Carter's election as the President, he continued to advice on foreign policy issues for years. President Carter was so admiring that he awarded Kissinger the Presidential Medal of Freedom in 1977. Graham Allison, author of "Destined for War, Can America and China escape Thucydides' Trap?" calls Kissinger his greatest mentor because he was "the exemplary statesman as applied historian." To President George W. Bush, Kissinger was "one of its most dependable and distinctive voices on foreign affairs." Kissinger "thrived on attention," was a skilled global strategist, and world class negotiator. He is credited to have transformed the world by breaking down barriers and fostering common ground.

Nepal in Kissinger's perspective

Kissinger wrote in his book World Order 2014, (p.179), "For centuries Nepal skillfully balanced its diplomatic posture between the ruling dynasties in China and those in India –offering letters and gifts that were interpreted as tribute China but recorded as evidence of equal exchanges in Nepal, then holding out a special tie with China as a guarantee of Nepal's independence vis-à-vis India."

In 1983, the late King Birendra visited the United States. President Ronald Reagan welcomed the King by describing "Nepal as a neighbour on the other side of the world," lent his support to King's proposal to have Nepal declared as a Zone of Peace and advised, "Nepal should work closely with her neighbors to make the Peace Zone proposal a reality." Kissinger, in a brief encounter with the Nepali press after meeting the King during his US visit, said that for Nepal "being surrounded by great powers, a little country between two elephants, it is important to have a Zone of Peace" (Call for Peace, 1983, 17). Kissinger visited Nepal in January 1985 and was hosted by the Nepal Council of World Affairs. Dissecting his writings could provide insights into the interplay among big powers in the rapidly changing geopolitical landscape.

(Bhattarai, Ph. D., is a faculty member of the Institute of Crisis Management Studies (ICMS), Tribhuvan University. dineshbhattarai@tuicms.edu.np)

Learning Tourism Lesson From Arunachal



Namrata Sharma

INSIGHT

Nepal could learn a lot of strategies of promoting the oranges of Gorkha from the policies taken by Arunachal Pradesh, the northernmost state of India. "Arunachal produces the best oranges in the country and we aim to increase production, so this festival has helped us in projecting our oranges at a bigger level," said Pema Khandu, Chief Minister of Arunachal Pradesh, in an interview with this scribe while inaugurating the Orange Festival of Music and Adventure (OFAM) at Dambuk, Dibang Valley, during 14th -18th December 2023.

One excellent tourism strategy that the Arunachal government has taken that Nepal Government can learn from is the way the OFAM is organised in Dambuk. This is in the Lower Dibang Valley which is one of the least populated districts of India. Arunachal government has initiated an annual function since 2015 which aims at boosting its economy by promoting tourism and selling one of its produces – orange - to the global market by popularising the fact that its taste and sweetness is better than oranges produced in other parts of India, even Nagpur. Oranges from Arunachal Pradesh, comparable to the oranges of Nagpur, are known for their delicacy only recently. Now these organic oranges are in high demand not only in the Middle East but in western countries and Japan.

Commercial promotion

The Arunachal government has been facilitating the hosting OFAM every year. To attract tourists, OFAM includes adventures involving off-road driving, zip lines, gas balloons, river rafting, trekking, cultural and traditional dances, Arunachal cuisine and an excellent musical live show of different genres targeted towards people of different age groups. This includes popular bands not only from India but from South Korea, USA, England and even Nepal. The experience of sipping orange juice, or local rice wines, munching oranges or other excellent delicacies in this remote but beautiful, romantic and tranquil town is something that everyone will cherish throughout their life.

Abu Tayeng, secretary of Sports and Youth Affairs, Arunachal has been the brain behind OFAM right from its inception and say that while in 2015 there was hardly any place to lodge guests and artistes with no private sector involvement, the year 2023 has big companies like JK tyres supporting the government initiative to promote oranges and tourism of this state. Arunachal Pradesh and all the states of the North East (NE) of India bear a lot of similarities with Nepal. Many of them have 20 to 30 per cent of Nepali origin residents and feel very proud of the fact that they are Indians, but they maintain their Nepali culture and heritage. They are also accepted fully as citizens there, who are part of the economy, politics and the society.

Arunachal Pradesh is landlocked and has snow-capped mountains, hills, and rivers like the Brahmaputra, which captures the minds of the nature lovers and the spiritually-inclined people. It is the state where the sun rays touch the Indian soil for the first time every morning and is known as the Land of the Dawn-lit Mountains. It lies in the Northeastern tip of India bordering China, Bhutan and Myanmar. It is in fact one of the remotest States of India. Given the sensitivity around border security of India, this remote Indian state has been neglected from mainstream development that other states of India have enjoyed. It also has border disputes with neighbouring State Assam. But now this is changing.

> One excellent tourism strategy that the Arunachal government has taken that Nepal Government can learn from is the way the OFAM is organised in Dambuk.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the BJP government are credited for bringing policies and strategies to develop the NE States of India, especially Arunachal Pradesh, said a prominent journalist based in Kolkata. This statement was validated by CM Khandu, during an interaction with me. This festival was possible because of improvements in infrastructure projects such as roads and bridges during PM Modi's tenure. He said that these infrastructure projects had helped in boosting Arunachal Pradesh's economy. When asked about the stability of the state, he said that the dispute with China was now neutralised and the land dispute of state borders between Assam and Arunachal have been resolved.

Public mobility

The general people want to see development and, with the current government in seat, they feel this is possible. The Dr Bhupen Hazarika Bridge, which was inaugurated by Narendra Modi in 2017, is known as a major bridge between Dhola and Sadias Ghats. This bridge joins Assam and Arunachal Pradesh and the people of the two states feel that initiatives like this have helped in resolving land disputes between the two states and also providing a beam of hope for the people of the North Eastern states to build their economy and have more mobility within the region and country. This bridge is the first permanent road connection between northern Assam and Eastern Arunachal Pradesh. This bridge has also helped in boosting tourism in the region.

Lakhpa Tsering, one of the main organisers of the festival, said the private sector is now fully supporting to improving OFAM and making boost the economy of the State. He also shared that some of the key event managements like the off-road driving and other activities were managed by Nepali residents of Arunachal and Assam. He stressed that there was a big scope for promotion of tourism and different products between Nepal and Arunachal.

(Sharma is a senior journalist and women rights advocate. namrata1964@yahoo.com Twitter handle: @ NamrataSharmaP)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

December 27, 1973

Medical Team Begins Work

Surkhet, Dec 26: The 22-member medical team from Kathmandu has started its work in Surkhet, report RSS.

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READER'S MAIL

Give Top Priority To Agriculture



I am writing this letter with regard to the news about the smooth supply of chemical fertilisers to farmers across the country your esteemed daily published on Tuesday. The news presents that the government has prioritised the agriculture sector.

It is indeed commendable that, within a year of its formation, the government has imported 500,000 tonnes of chemical fertilisers and has distributed over 400,000 tonnes of its to the farmers. This positive development not only ensures the sustenance of our agricultural sector but also contributes to the national economy.

Furthermore, a thriving agricultural sector is crucial for food security, rural development and the livelihoods of millions of farmers who form the backbone of our society.

Nevertheless, the government continue prioritising the agriculture sector and do more to ensure that every farmer in every corner of the country is able to access government services and initiatives.

Past governments may or may not have understood the value of agriculture, but the present and future governments must.

Iman Dev Karki
Maharajgunj, Kathmandu

TAILPIECE

Once two star football players had failed a test, and could not play football in the championship game.

So, after much begging from the coach, the teacher finally let the two take the test again.

They took the test, and turned it in.

The coach and the two students watched carefully over the teacher grading the tests. She checked over the first test, then over the second test. Half way through the second test she stopped and put a great big 'F' on both tests.

The coach was furious and demanded an explanation. She said that they had cheated. 'Why?' the coach asked. The teacher showed him number six. The coach looked at number six on the first test. The answer read 'I don't know.' The coach said that it did not prove anything. The teacher handed him the second test. The answer read 'I don't know either.'

US carries out air strikes in Iraq

AFP
Iraq, Dec. 26

The US military carried out strikes on three sites used by Iran-backed forces in Iraq on Monday after an attack wounded three American personnel earlier in the day, Defense Secretary Lloyd Austin said.

Washington has repeatedly targeted sites used by Iran and its proxy forces in Iraq and Syria in response to dozens of attacks on American and allied forces in the region since the October 7 outbreak of the Israel-Hamas war.

"US military forces conducted necessary and proportionate strikes on three facilities used by Kataeb Hezbollah and affiliated groups in Iraq," Austin said in a statement.

"These precision strikes are a response to a series of attacks against US personnel in Iraq and Syria by Iranian-sponsored militias, including an attack by Iran-affiliated Kataeb Hezbollah and affiliated groups on Arbil Air Base earlier today," he said.

That attack wounded three US military personnel, one critically, US National Security Council spokesperson Adrienne Watson said in a statement.

President Joe Biden was briefed on the attack—which was carried out with a one-way attack drone—and directed the strikes in a call with Austin and other national security officials after ordering the Defense Department to prepare a response, the statement said.

Biden "places no higher priority than the protection of American personnel serving in harm's way. The United States will act at a time and in a manner of our choosing should these attacks continue," the statement added.

The drone attack was claimed by the Islamic Resistance in Iraq, a loose formation of armed groups affiliated with the Hashed al-Shaabi coalition of former paramilitaries that are now integrated into Iraq's regular armed forces.



PHOTO: AFP

US Defence Secretary Lloyd Austin said the precision air strikes were carried out as a response to a series of attacks against US personnel in Iraq and Syria by Iranian-sponsored militias.

A tally by US military officials has counted 103 attacks against its troops in Iraq and Syria since October 17, most of which have been claimed by the Islamic Resistance in Iraq, which opposes US support for Israel in its war against Hamas in the Gaza Strip.

The latest round of the Israel-Hamas conflict began when the Palestinian militant group carried out a shock cross-border attack from Gaza on October 7 that killed about 1,140 people, mostly civilians according to an AFP tally based on Israeli figures.

Following the attack, the United States rushed military aid to Israel, which has carried out a relentless campaign in Gaza that has killed at least 20,670 people, also mostly civilians, according to the Hamas-run territory's health ministry.

Those deaths have sparked widespread anger in the Middle East and provided an impetus for attacks on American troops by forces opposed to their presence in the region.

There are roughly 2,500 American troops in Iraq and some 900 in Syria as part of efforts to prevent a resurgence of the Islamic State group.

The militants once held significant territory in both countries but were pushed back by local ground forces supported by international air strikes in a bloody, multi-year conflict.

140 villagers killed in Nigeria

AP
Nigeria, Dec. 26

At least 140 people were killed by gunmen who attacked remote villages over two days in north-central Nigeria's Plateau state, survivors and officials said Tuesday in the latest of such mass killings this year blamed on the West African nation's farmer-herder crisis.

The assailants targeted 17 communities during the "senseless and unprovoked" attacks on Saturday and Sunday, during which most houses in the areas were burned down, Plateau Gov. Caleb Mutfwang said Tuesday in a broadcast on the local Channels Television.

"As I am talking to you, in Mangu local government alone, we buried 15 people. As of this morning, in Bokkos, we are counting not less than 100 corpses. I am yet to take stock of (the deaths in) Barkin Ladi," Gov. Mutfwan said. "It has been a very terrifying Christmas for us here in Plateau."

Amnesty International Nigeria's office told The Associated Press that it has so far confirmed 140 deaths in the Christian-dominated Bokkos and Barkin-Ladi local government areas of Plateau based on data compiled by its workers on the ground and from local officials, though locals feared a higher death toll with some people unaccounted for.

Some of the locals said that it took more than 12 hours before security agencies responded to their call for help, a claim the AP couldn't independently verify, but which echoes past concerns about slow interventions in Nigeria's deadly security crisis, which has killed hundreds this year, including in Plateau.

"I called security but they never came. The ambush started 6 in the evening but security reached our place by 7 in the morning," said Sunday Dawum, a youth leader in Bokkos. At least 27 people were killed in his village, Mbom Mbaru, including his brother, he said.

No group took responsibility for the attacks though the blame fell on herders from the Fulani tribe, who have been accused of carrying out such mass killings across the northwest and central regions where the decades long conflict over access to land and water has further worsened the sectarian division between Christians and Muslims in Africa's most populous nation.

276 Indians stuck in France arrive India

AFP
Mumbai, Dec. 26

A plane grounded in France for days over concerns it was part of a human trafficking scheme landed in India Tuesday, with its passengers avoiding media questions as they quickly exited bustling Mumbai airport.

The Airbus A340 initially had been bound for Nicaragua when it was detained last Thursday at Vatry airport, east of Paris, where it had stopped for refuelling.

It had arrived from the United Arab Emirates and was halted after an anonymous tip-off that it was carrying potential victims of human trafficking.

Of the original 303 people on the passenger list, 276 were on the plane that arrived in Mumbai before dawn on Tuesday.

Passengers began walking out onto the concourse four hours later but refused to speak to a large crowd of waiting journalists and covered their faces to shield their identities.

It was unclear whether the arrivals were questioned by authorities and India's government has yet to issue a statement on their return.

Among those staying behind in France were two people questioned by police there over suspected people trafficking. A judicial source said they were released after it was established the passengers had boarded the plane of their own free will.

French authorities are continuing to investigate the case for a potential violation of immigration laws, but no longer for people trafficking, judicial sources said. Another 25 passengers sought asylum in France including five minors, local officials said.

A source close to the inquiry told AFP that those aboard were likely workers in the UAE bound for Nicaragua, which they intended to use as a staging post for journeys to the United States or Canada.

Authorisation for the plane to leave France came after a court ruled that any further detention of three of its passengers would be illegal.

The passengers of the flight, operated by Romanian company Legend Airlines, were put up at Vatry airport during the investigation.

Beds, toilets and showers were installed, the local prefecture said, while police prevented press and outsiders from entering the airport.

The passengers included 11 unaccompanied minors, according to Paris prosecutors. The Indian embassy in Paris posted on X, formerly Twitter, on Monday that it was grateful for the "quick resolution" of the incident.

The 30 crew members were not detained. Some had handled the Dubai-Vatry leg while others were to take over for the flight to Nicaragua.

Last year the issue caught public attention when four Indians froze to death while trying to cross into the United States on foot from the Canadian border.

Ukrainian attack damages Russian naval ship

REUTERS
Russia, Dec. 26

A Ukrainian attack on the Crimean port of Feodosia damaged a large Russian landing ship and killed one person, Moscow said on Tuesday after Kyiv said it had destroyed an important Russian warship.

The Russian defence ministry was cited by the Interfax news agency as saying that Ukraine had used air-launched missiles to attack Feodosia and that the "Novocherkassk" large landing ship had been damaged in the raid.

The Novocherkassk, which was built in Poland and entered service in the late 1980s, is designed for amphibious landings and can carry various types of armoured vehicles, including tanks.

Footage posted on several Russian news outlets on the Telegram messaging app, purportedly from the port, showed powerful explosions detonating and fires burning.

Sergei Aksyonov, the Russian-installed governor of Crimea, said on the Telegram messaging app that one person had been killed, two injured and six people evacuated from their homes.

Although a Ukrainian counteroffensive has made little in the way of battlefield gains and the Russian military has regained the initiative in several places, Ukraine has been able to launch a series of attacks on Crimea, the headquarters of Russia's Black Sea Fleet, inflicting serious damage.



PHOTO: REUTERS

The large Russian landing ship Novocherkassk was damaged after it was hit by missiles fired by Ukrainian forces.

The Ukrainian air force said its pilots had attacked Feodosia at about 0230 (0030 GMT) with cruise missiles, destroying the Novocherkassk.

"And the fleet in Russia is getting smaller and smaller! Thanks to the Air Force pilots and everyone involved for the filigree work!" the commander of Ukraine's air force, Mykola Oleshchuk, said on Telegram.

A statement from the Russian-installed administration of Crimea said that trains were not running from Feodosia and advised people to use an alternative nearby station.

Feodosia, which has a population of around 69,000 people, lies on the southern coast of the Crimean Peninsula.

Russia annexed Crimea from Ukraine in 2014 in a move Kyiv and the West condemned as an illegal seizure.

PRISM

Banksy stop sign nabbed with bolt cutters

London: The elusive artist Banksy displayed his latest work on a London street corner and it was taken less than hour after he confirmed its installation Friday.

A red stop sign with three military drones on it was taken in the middle of the day by a man with bolt cutters as witnesses snapped photos and shot video in the Peckham section of south London.

People commenting on Banksy's Instagram accurately predicted it wouldn't be there long after the artist posted a photo of it. Some of his work has sold for tens of millions of dollars.

"I went there thinking that people want that, I wanted to see it before something happened to it," a man who only wanted to be known as Alex told the Press Association.

He was among the many onlookers who watched in awe as a man in a red and black jacket climbed up on a bike next to the post where the sign was bolted to and began hitting it with his hands.

Woman with double uterus gives birth to two children

DORA, Ala.: An Alabama woman with two uteri and two cervixes has given birth to two babies after carrying one of them in each uterus. Kelsey Hatcher of Dora, about 28 miles (45.06 kilometers) northwest of Birmingham, gave birth to two girls on Wednesday and Thursday after a combined 20 hours of labor.

Hatcher was diagnosed with a double uterus, also called uterus didelphys, when she was 17. The rare congenital condition occurs in 0.3% of women, according to a report published by the University of Alabama at Birmingham. There is an "estimated one-in-a-million chance" of carrying a baby in both uteri, also known as a dicavitary pregnancy, the report says.

The older child, Roxi, was born on Tuesday, and Rebel arrived on Wednesday. Hatcher told WVTM-TV that both she and the newborns are healthy. Her husband, Caleb, was with her in the hospital, she said.

(AP)

TODAY IN HISTORY

1703 – Portugal and England sign the Methuen Treaty which allows Portugal to export wines to England on favourable trade terms.

1831 – Charles Darwin embarks on his journey aboard HMS Beagle, during which he will begin to formulate his theory of evolution.

1918 – The Great Poland Uprising against the Germans begins.

1918 – Ukrainian War of Independence: The Revolutionary Insurgent Army of Ukraine occupies Yekaterinoslav and seizes seven airplanes from the UPRAF, establishing an Insurgent Air Fleet.

1989 – The Romanian Revolution concludes, as the last minor street confrontations and stray shootings abruptly end in the country's capital, Bucharest.

2007 – Former Pakistani prime minister Benazir Bhutto is assassinated in a shooting incident.

Right to protest is under threat in Britain

AP
London, Dec. 27

For holding a sign outside a courthouse reminding jurors of their right to acquit defendants, a retiree faces up to two years in prison. For hanging a banner reading Just Stop Oil off a bridge, an engineer got a three-year sentence. Just for walking slowly down the street, scores of people have been arrested.

They are among hundreds of environmental activists arrested for peaceful demonstrations in the U.K., where tough new laws restrict the right to protest.

The Conservative government says the laws prevent extremist activists from hurting the economy and disrupting daily life. Critics say the arrests mark a worrying departure.

"The government has made its intent very clear, which is basically to suppress what is legitimate, lawful protest," said Jonathon Porritt, an ecologist and former director of Friends of the Earth.

Britain is one of the world's oldest democracies, home of the Magna Carta, a centuries-old Parliament and an independent judiciary. That system is underpinned by an "unwritten constitution" — a set of laws, rules, conventions and judicial decisions accumulated over the years.

The result is "we rely on self-restraint by governments," said Andrew Blick, author of "Democratic Turbulence in the United Kingdom" and a political scientist at King's College London. "You hope the people in power are going to behave themselves."



PHOTO: AP

An activist from the group Just Stop Oil is arrested by police officers as they slow the traffic, marching on a road, in London, Monday, Oct. 30, 2023.

But what if they don't? During three scandal-tarnished years in office, Boris Johnson pushed prime ministerial power to the limits. More recently, Prime Minister Rishi Sunak asked Parliament to overrule the U.K. Supreme Court, which blocked a plan to send asylum-seekers to Rwanda.

Critics say cracks have appeared in Britain's democratic foundations.

As former Conservative justice minister David Lidington put it: "The 'good chap' theory of checks and balances has now been tested to destruction."

The canaries in the coal mine are environmental activists who have blocked roads and bridges, glued themselves to trains, splattered artworks with paint, sprayed buildings with fake blood and doused athletes in orange powder to draw attention to climate change. Groups such as Extinction Rebellion, Just Stop Oil and Insulate Britain argue that civil disobedience is justified, but Sunak has called them "ideological zealots."

In 2022, a statutory offense of "public nuisance" was created, punishable by up to 10 years in prison. The 2023 Public Order Act broadened the definition of disruptive protest, increased police search powers and imposed penalties of up to 12 months in prison for protesters who block roads or other "key infrastructure."

In May, six anti-monarchist activists were arrested before the coronation of King Charles III before they had so much as held up a "Not My King" placard. All were released without charge.

In recent months, hundreds of Just Stop Oil activists have been detained under a new rule that criminalizes slow walking protests. Some protesters have received prison sentences that have been called unduly punitive.

Structural engineer Morgan Trowland was one of two activists who scaled a bridge over the River Thames in October 2022, forcing police to shut the highway below for 40 hours. He was sentenced to three years in prison.

He was released early on Dec. 13 after 14 months in custody.

Ian Fry, the United Nations' rapporteur for climate change and human rights, has called Britain's anti-protest law a "direct attack on the right to the freedom of peaceful assembly."

The Conservative government has dismissed the criticism. "Those who break the law should feel the full force of it," Sunak said.

Even more worrying, some legal experts say, is the "justice lottery." Half the environmentalists tried by juries have been acquitted after explaining their motivations. But at other trials, judges have banned defendants from mentioning climate change or their reasons for protesting. Several defendants who defied the orders were jailed for contempt of court.

Tim Crosland, a former government lawyer turned environmental activist, said the silencing of defendants "feels like something that happens in Russia or China, not here."

To highlight concern, retired social worker Trudi Warner sat outside a London court in March holding a sign reading "Jurors – You have an absolute right to acquit a defendant according to your conscience." She is now being prosecuted. Many legal and constitutional experts say the treatment of protesters is a symptom of an increasingly reckless attitude toward Britain's democratic structures that has been fueled by Brexit.

The 2016 referendum on whether to leave the European Union was won by a populist "leave" campaign that promised to restore Parliament's – and by extension the public's -- sovereignty.

The divorce brought to power Boris Johnson, who tested Britain's unwritten constitution. When lawmakers blocked his attempts to leave the EU without an agreement, he suspended Parliament -- until the U.K. Supreme Court ruled that illegal. He later proposed breaking international law by reneging on the U.K.'s exit treaty with the bloc.

He was ejected from office by his own fed-up lawmakers in 2022 after a series of personal scandals. "People were elevated to high office (by Brexit) who then behaved in ways which were difficult to reconcile with maintenance of a stable democracy," said Blick, the King's College professor.

PRESIDENT EXPRESSES CONCERN OVER 'EMPTY VILLAGES'

RSS
Kathmandu, Dec. 26

President Ramchandra Paudel has expressed his concern over villages turning 'empty' due to rampant migration to urban areas.

In his address to a function marking the 65th anniversary of Thamel-based Saraswoti Multiple Campus today, the Head of the State urged one and all to seek ways to address the situation.

He said villages face depopulation despite advancements in education, communications, road, health and electricity sectors after the advent of democracy. Villages experience a population decline to consume the benefits of developments, according to the President.

Stressing that education system of any nation should be determined by given socio-economic situation and other needs, the President advised authorities to formulate education policies and programmes capable of producing globally competitive human resources. "Combined efforts are necessary towards this end and academic institutions should take its initiations."

He urged policymakers and relevant authorities to concentrate on finding solutions to address the issue and highlighted the need of promoting job opportunities and vocational education to prevent the widespread migrations of youths in search of careers abroad. He said he was pleased to be part of the anniversary celebrations of the campus carrying a history of 65 years.

The President who was once a student of this college said he had given his fertile time to the movement for democracy as the college student. According to him, the college atmosphere had played a role to further enhance his political awakening and thus his political career.

President Paudel mentioned that Saraswoti Campus has become the source of inspiration for Nepal's education sector as it had provided opportunity for pursuing higher education in easy and accessible manner in those days when it was very difficult for Nepalese youths to get education.

"Not having physical infrastructures with campus even in present situation is the matter of concern. I urge the government to provide special support for physical infrastructures of the country's oldest and leading educational institution, Saraswoti Campus," he shared.

Similarly, Acting Vice Chancellor of the Tribhuvan University Prof Dr Shiva Lal Bhusal pointed out the need of strengthening the existing educational institutions rather than establishing new ones.

Achievements could be gained only if the university is connected with State's plan, he said.

Founding Campus Chief of the Campus, Prof Shankar Raj Pathak, recalled that President Paudel was very active during his student life and expressed the belief that the country would achieve development and prosperity from President Paudel's activeness.



PHOTO: KABIN ADHIKARI/TRN
President Ramchandra Paudel addressing a ceremony organised to mark 65th anniversary of Saraswati Multiple Campus in Kathmandu on Tuesday.

Chief Ministers of all provinces meeting in Hetauda to demand rights

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Hetauda, Dec. 26

Chief Ministers of all seven provinces are holding a meeting on Thursday in Hetauda to discuss the rights of the provincial and local level governments.

The office of the Bagmati Province Chief Minister and the Council of Ministries on Tuesday informed that the discussions on the detailed expansion of shared rights, the legislative process, sectors of financial and economic development, service sectors, infrastructure, forestry and environment and disaster management would be held along with the presentation of working papers. Following the discussion, a joint report is also set to be approved.

The discussion scheduled for Thursday and Friday is expected to be attended by Chief Secretaries of all seven provinces, Chief Attorneys, representatives of the National Association of Rural Municipalities and the Nepal Municipality Association.

Meanwhile, the Bagmati Province government has approached the Supreme Court claiming that the federal government had intervened in the exclusive rights of the provinces regarding transportation as mentioned in the constitution.

Earlier, the Ministers for Internal Affairs and Law from all seven provinces submitted a letter of concerned provinces to Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' and Deputy Prime Minister and Home Minister Narayan Kaji Shrestha demanding the adjustment of police forces in the provinces.

Provincial govt should be granted rights: Lumbini CM

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Rupandehi, Dec. 26

Lumbini Province Chief Minister Dilli Bahadur Chaudhary has said that implementing federalism has been challenging due to the central government's failure to provide adequate rights.

Speaking at the 11th annual general meeting of the Gautam Buddha Community Health Institute in Butwal on Tuesday, the Chief Minister said that the central government should grant sufficient rights to both provincial and local level governments.

He said that people were confused about federalism due to the lack of full exercise of the rights guaranteed by the Constitution.

> People are confused about federalism due to the lack of full exercise of the rights guaranteed by the Constitution.

He said many development projects face problems because the rights for the distribution and management of public land were assigned to the provincial government and forest rights remained with the central government.

Chief Minister Chaudhary urged health institutions to provide easy and accessible healthcare services to the people of Lumbini Province.

Ajaz Alam, president of the Gautam Buddha Community Health Institute, informed that the institute had been serving patients not only from Lumbini Province but also from 44 districts.

He said that the institute faced problems in expanding its services due to insufficient land.

Former Health Minister and Member of Lumbini Province Assembly Bhoj Prasad Shrestha stressed the need for amending certain government laws not favourable to community-run health and educational institutions.

PRESERVATION OF CULTURE COMMON RESPONSIBILITY

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 26

Please scan the QR code for related video

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has called the preservation of culture "the common responsibility of all Nepalis."

Speaking at a programme held in Kathmandu on Tuesday on the occasion of the 20th National Jyapu Day, Prime Minister Prachanda said that the cultural identity of various ethnic, linguistic and cultural groups was a matter of pride for all Nepalis and called on everyone to protect indigenous traditions.

"Our festivals, heritage and culture are priceless treasures of our country," he said, believing that the National Jyapu Day would strengthen harmony, tolerance and fraternity among people from various religious, geographic and communal backgrounds.

The Prime Minister further said that the government had been appreciating the efforts made by the Jyapu community of the Kathmandu Metropolitan City to keep their culture and customs alive. He also stressed the Government of Nepal's commitment to the protection and promotion of tangible and intangible culture.

Prachanda used the occasion to remind everyone that he had declared Nepal Sambat a national calendar during his first term as Prime Minister. "Now, in my third term, we have made it mandatory to mention the Nepal Sambat date on official documents," he continued.

Similarly, he stated that he had been fighting for the rights of all classes, castes, regions, genders and communities, in line with the characteristics and structure of Nepali society.

STEAMERS PROVIDED TO BHIMPHEDI PRISON

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Hetauda, Dec. 26

The Manahari Rural Municipality has provided two rice steamers, together worth Rs. 300,000, to the Bhimphedi Prison. The prison had so far been using a heater to cook food for its inmates. To bring an end to this situation, the rural municipality handed over the steamers on Tuesday.

The rural municipality's rural municipal executive decided to provide the prison with the two steamers on September 21. Ranjan Kalakheti, chairman of the rural municipality, said that the local level gave the steamers as part of its social responsibility.

Each of the two steamers can cook 48 kilograms of rice at once which, in turn, can feed 200 individuals.

Bhimphedi Prison currently houses 1,069 prisoners.

Operational approach of...

Out of this, power purchase agreements for about 2,200 megawatts have been completed this year alone, he said.

Similarly, Prime Minister Prachanda said that the government is planning to implement the subsidy system based on production of power.

Prachanda said, "State investment in agriculture has not decreased but productivity has not increased. Agricultural loans at subsidised rates will be extended to real farmers."

He said that the subsidies provided in the agricultural sector will be integrated within this fiscal year and distribution of subsidies and fertilisers will be started from the next year based on the list of farmers.

"Production based subsidy system is being implemented for major food grains and vegetables. The remaining dues of milk farmers are being paid by mid-April 2024.

However, we are not in a situation where the agricultural sector will take a leap with these reforms alone," he said.

Stating that about 400,000 tonnes of chemical fertilisers have been ensured on time, he said that irrigation facilities have been provided in 21,169 hectares of land in a year through surface and underground irrigation projects.

"Agriculture is no longer possible to conduct in a traditional way. For the transformation of the food system and the agricultural sector, the government is ready to move forward by announcing the Decade of Investment in the Agricultural Sector (2081-2091) to increase investment of the government, private sector, development partners and cooperative sector," said the Prime Minister.

Prime Minister Prachanda claimed that tourist numbers reached a record high this fiscal year.

The Prime Minister said that while it may sound unbelievable now, he felt that the number of tourists coming to Nepal could double next year. "The Great Lumbini Project, which incorporates an area of eight square kilometres around Lumbini, is moving ahead. The Ramgram and Kapilvastu master plans are under implementation. The government has devised different strategies for tourists from different regions," he said in his speech.

Regarding the operation of the Gautam Buddha and Pokhara international airports, he said that the government would provide subsidies on service charges related to fuel, terminal and ground handling, among others, to incentivise international carriers to fly here. For Gautam Buddha International Airport, he informed that steps were being taken to have small planes operate low-altitude flights from neighbouring countries.

Prachanda also stressed the need to ensure the construction of an international airport at Nijgadh in Bara district.

'Nepal should benefit from...

Congratulating China on the occasion of the completion of 10 years of the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI), she said that the establishment of the project as a financial support platform for 150 countries and 30 international organisations within the duration is an important milestone and Nepal should also work hard to gain from them.

"The media of both countries have an important role in promoting government-to-government and people-to-people relation to a higher level, and such conferences will be fruitful in this regard," said Minister Sharma.

She expressed her belief that since there are a large number of Buddhist pilgrims in China, if only a small per cent of them can come to Nepal, the birthplace of Gautam Buddha, there will be a transformation in Nepal's tourism market.

Stating that the civilisation and relationship between the two countries started with the trade exchange between Nepal and China, especially in salt, wool and gold, she also clarified that Nepal expects to become a business partner with China to reduce the trade deficit that Nepal has been experiencing for years.

Nepal has been deeply interested in opening more business points with China, facilitating customs points and giving customs exemptions, said Sharma.

As there is a common understanding in both the political and media sectors, now the mission of both politics and journalism should be to bring about a qualitative change in the condition of the people.

For this, the government has moved ahead with the objective good governance, prosperity and social justice as its main agenda, Minister Sharma said.

The current government has a clear opinion that criticisms and warnings from the media can stop the political forces including the government from going on the wrong path, Minister Sharma said.

Egypt floats plan to end Israel-Hamas war

AP
Cairo, Dec 26

Israel and Hamas on Monday gave cool public receptions to an Egyptian proposal to end their bitter war. But the longstanding enemies stopped short of rejecting the plan altogether, raising the possibility of a new round of diplomacy to halt a devastating Israeli offensive in the Gaza Strip.

The Egyptian plan calls for a phased hostage release and the formation of a Palestinian government of experts to administer the Gaza Strip and occupied West Bank, according to a senior Egyptian official and a European diplomat familiar with the proposal.

The Egyptian official, speaking on condition of anonymity to discuss the proposal, said the details were worked out with the Gulf nation of Qatar and presented to Israel, Hamas, the United States and European governments. Egypt and Qatar both mediate between Israel and Hamas, while the U.S. is Israel's closest ally and a key power in the region.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu did not comment directly on the proposal. But speaking to members of his Likud Party, he said he was determined to press ahead with Israel's offensive, launched in response to an Oct. 7 Hamas attack on southern Israel that killed 1,200 people and took 240 others hostage. "We are expanding the fight in the coming days and this will be a long battle and it isn't close to finished," he said.



Hamas has continued to fire rockets into Israel throughout the fighting. Late Monday, it launched a barrage of rockets, triggering air raid sirens in the southern city of Ashkelon. AP video showed what appeared to be several interceptions by Israel's rocket defense system. There were no immediate reports of damage or injuries.

The Egyptian proposal falls short of Israel's declared goal of crushing Hamas. It also appears to be at odds with Israel's insistence on maintaining military control over Gaza for an extended period after the war.

But Netanyahu faces heavy domestic pressure to reach a deal to bring home the more than 100 Israeli hostages who remain in captivity in Gaza.

As he vowed to continue the war during a speech in parliament, relatives of the hostages interrupted him and called for their immediate return. "Now! Now!" they shouted.

The rising death toll of Israeli soldiers from the ground operation also threatens to undermine public support for the war. The Israeli military announced the deaths of two more soldiers Monday, bringing the total killed in the war to 156. Netanyahu's War Cabinet was expected to meet late Monday. It was unclear if they would discuss the Egyptian proposal.

Hamas did not officially react to the proposal. But it is unclear if Hamas would agree to relinquish power after controlling Gaza for the past 16 years.

Izzat Rishq, a senior Hamas official who is believed to be based in Qatar, issued a statement repeating the group's position that it will not negotiate without a "complete end to the aggression." He said Hamas would not agree to a "temporary or partial truce for a short period of time."

Singers, artistes mesmerising audience in Nepalgunj festival

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Nepalgunj, Dec. 26



The 6th Nepalgunj Festival is drawing a crowd.

The main attraction of the festival being held in Nepalgunj is the captivating performances by both national and local artistes and singers.

Most of the ordinary attendees at the festival are observed to sit in front of the cultural stage, indulging in the enjoyment of songs, dances, and art.

The vegetable goers have been enthralled by the performances of renowned artists such as Eleena Chauhan, Tanka Timilsina, Ram Ji Khand, Priti Ale, and Biraj Bhatt, who have graced the festival with their presence.

Notably, the recent inclusion of Puskal Sharma has added to the festive spirit, with his performance of the popular song 'Ma Jiuna Sakdina Mutu Jalai' leaving the audience mesmerised.

Puskal Sharma's repertoire, including hits like 'Ho Bhana Nirmaya', 'Chhoddina Hai Timilai', 'Gayema Ho Kaliganga Tarera', 'Malai Maaf Gara', 'Kahile Ye Sathi' received thunderous applause and cheers from the enthusiastic audience.

In addition to the musical extravaganza, the festival, organised by AG Service and coordinated by Nanda Budha, boasts a diverse array of attractions.

These include various types of kindergarten exhibitions, a Tharu Village showcasing the local culture, photo session stalls, a wrestling competition featuring renowned athletes from Nepal and India, and powerful performances by both national and local artists. Furthermore, the festival offers the unique experience of Sony Dance.

Coordinator Nanda Budha highlighted that festival-goers can also savour authentic Tharu dishes in the Tharu Village while enjoying daily performances by national artists.

The festival will continue till January 2.

Shooting of 'Yo Mann Ta Mero Nepali Ho' concludes

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 26



The initial phase of shooting of the film 'Yo Mann Ta Mero Nepali Ho' has concluded.

The film's director, Mitra Pradhan, a Nepali Bhutanese writer based in America, informed that the film was shot in Nepal and India for over 30 days, specifically in locations such as Jhapa and Ilam in Nepal, and Sikkim, Darjeeling, and Jaigaon in West Bengal, India.

Director Pradhan informed that the remaining scenes of the film will be shot in America.

Ayusha Samal, the lead actress and the first runner-up of 'Mero Dance Cup USA', has already flown to America following the completion of the shooting in Nepal and India.

The cast includes Roshan Shrestha, Wilson Bikram Rai, Buddhi Tamang, Bijay Baral, Ayusha Samal, Meg Subedi, Narayan Khati, Bhupendra Lingden, Subash Bhandari, Bijay Subba, and others in pivotal roles.

Produced by Mitra Pradhan and presented by Padma Ishwar Entertainment, the movie aims to explore the themes of Nepali language, literature, art, history, and the pride associated with the language.

Written by Shivam Adhikari, the film endeavours to depict the allure, significance, and history of the Nepali language, emphasising the need to preserve Nepali art, culture, and tradition among those living in different parts of the world.

The film features cinematography by Saurav Lama, and Kaviraj Gahatraj serves as the choreographer.

The film unit claims that it aspires to shed light on the rich cultural heritage and linguistic identity of Nepal.

Beyoncé's childhood home in Houston burns on Christmas morning



AP
Texas, Dec. 26

Beyoncé's childhood home caught fire early on Christmas morning, though the family living there escaped safely.

The fire was reported at about 2 a.m. Monday and the Houston Fire Department arrived on the scene of the two-story brick house within three to five minutes, the Houston Chronicle reported.

"We had it contained in about 10 minutes," Houston Fire Department District Chief Justin Barnes told the newspaper.

Beyoncé Knowles' family bought the home on the 2400 block of Rosedale in 1982 and Beyoncé lived there until she was 5 years old. She was seen taking photos of the property when she was in her hometown for her Renaissance World Tour. The home in the historic Riverside Terrace neighborhood was built in 1946.

A messages sent to Beyoncé's publicist was not immediately returned late Monday.

The cause of the blaze was under investigation.

Finding new dimensions, sisterhood, and healing in 'The Color Purple'

AP
Los Angeles, Dec. 26



It's not a secret that Fantasia Barrino did not want to play Celie again. The "American Idol" winner hadn't had the best time doing "The Color Purple" on Broadway.

The protagonist of Alice Walker's Pulitzer Prize-winning novel tells her story of sexual, physical and psychological abuses in the early 20th century South in a series of letters to God. And it was a character she found it difficult to leave behind at the end of the day. Even the prospect of starring in her first major motion picture didn't seem worth it.

But director Blitz Bazawule had a different vision: He wanted to give Celie an imagination. This Barrino found intriguing.

"Once she understood the assignment, she quickly agreed," Bazawule said in a recent interview with The Associated Press.

Now, four decades after "The Color Purple" became a literary sensation and a Steven Spielberg film, the story is on the big screen again. This time it's a grand, big budget Warner Bros. musical starring Barrino, Taraji P. Henson, as the sultry singer Shug Avery, and Danielle Brooks, reprising her Broadway role as the strong-willed Sofia. It opens in theaters nationwide on Christmas.

"I'm glad that I didn't allow my fear of my past experience with Celie, because of where my life was at that time, to hinder me from doing something is great," Barrino said. "I'm riding on a high right now."

Oprah Winfrey is one of several big-name producers on "The Color Purple," alongside Spielberg, Quincy Jones and Scott Sanders. Winfrey got her acting break and first Oscar nomination playing Sofia in the 1985 adaptation, before helping Sanders turn it into a Broadway musical 20 years later.

Bazawule was not an obvious candidate to direct this film, however. The multi-hyphenate Ghanaian artist had received acclaim and recognition for co-directing Beyoncé's visual album "Black is King." The only other film he had under his belt was the microbudget "The Burial Of Kojo," which was made for less than $100,000.

But he had ambitious ideas involving large scale musical numbers that would take audiences on a dazzling journey through the history of Black music in America, from gospel to blues to jazz. And, of course, Celie's inner life. He wasn't at all sure he would get it, but he knew the story he wanted to tell.

"I thought, if I could just find a way to show the audience how this Black woman from the rural South was able to imagine her way out of pain and trauma it will debunk a myth that is that people who have dealt with abusing trauma are docile and passive or waiting to be saved," Bazawule said. "If we could just imbue in (Celie) that scale, then that's the version that needed to exist. Thankfully they said yes."

They would have to jump through some hoops, however, to secure the kind of budget (reportedly around $100 million) that they needed to support the vision, including auditioning Henson, an Oscar-nominated actor, and Brooks, who already had a Tony nomination for her portrayal of Sofia.

For Brooks, it was a six-month process that had her doubting herself. A lot of the people involved in "The Color Purple" felt the exhaustion of both having to prove themselves yet again, but also wanting to rise to the challenge nonetheless because this film was worth it.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

Aries: Hold your horses, Aries! There's no need to go careening off into the fray, even as Mercury and Mars conjoining in your expansion sector make rushing in seem awfully appealing. You should be patient and plan.

Taurus: Conversations are likely to be extra heated right now. Communicator Mercury is aligning with red-hot Mars in your 8th House of Shared Resources, which could force you to have some tough conversations.

Gemini: The blame game is not the way to go at present. It's easy to get into arguments about what someone said or did as Mercury and Mars conjoin in your relationship sector, especially because Mercury is retrograde.

Cancer: It's not your imagination if your usual routine feels like a battlefield. Your 6th House of Daily Effort is hosting a rare conjunction between Mercury and Mars, so everyone is extra heated and ready to go!

Leo: All the world's a stage -- until you make a public embarrassment of yourself. Normally you can show off with the best of them, but an alignment between retrograde-muddled Mercury and tenacious Mars could inspire you to put yourself front and center.

Virgo: It's one thing after another before you even get to leave your front door! A strong conjunction between Mercury and Mars in your home sector could turn your place into the setting for some major action, but with Mercury tumbling retrograde at present.

Libra: Your words are coming out sharper than usual. Courier Mercury and warrior Mars are conjoining in your 3rd House of Communications, which could give every interaction an extra edge.

Scorpio: Getting rich quick is even less likely than usual. You may receive an offer or some kind of financial opportunity as Mercury and Mars team up in your 2nd House of Finances. The only problem with this is that Mercury is currently retrograde.

Sagittarius: Left is right and right is left at the moment. It's totally understandable if you feel pulled in multiple directions, thanks to the fact that Mercury and Mars are making a powerful alignment in your very own sign.

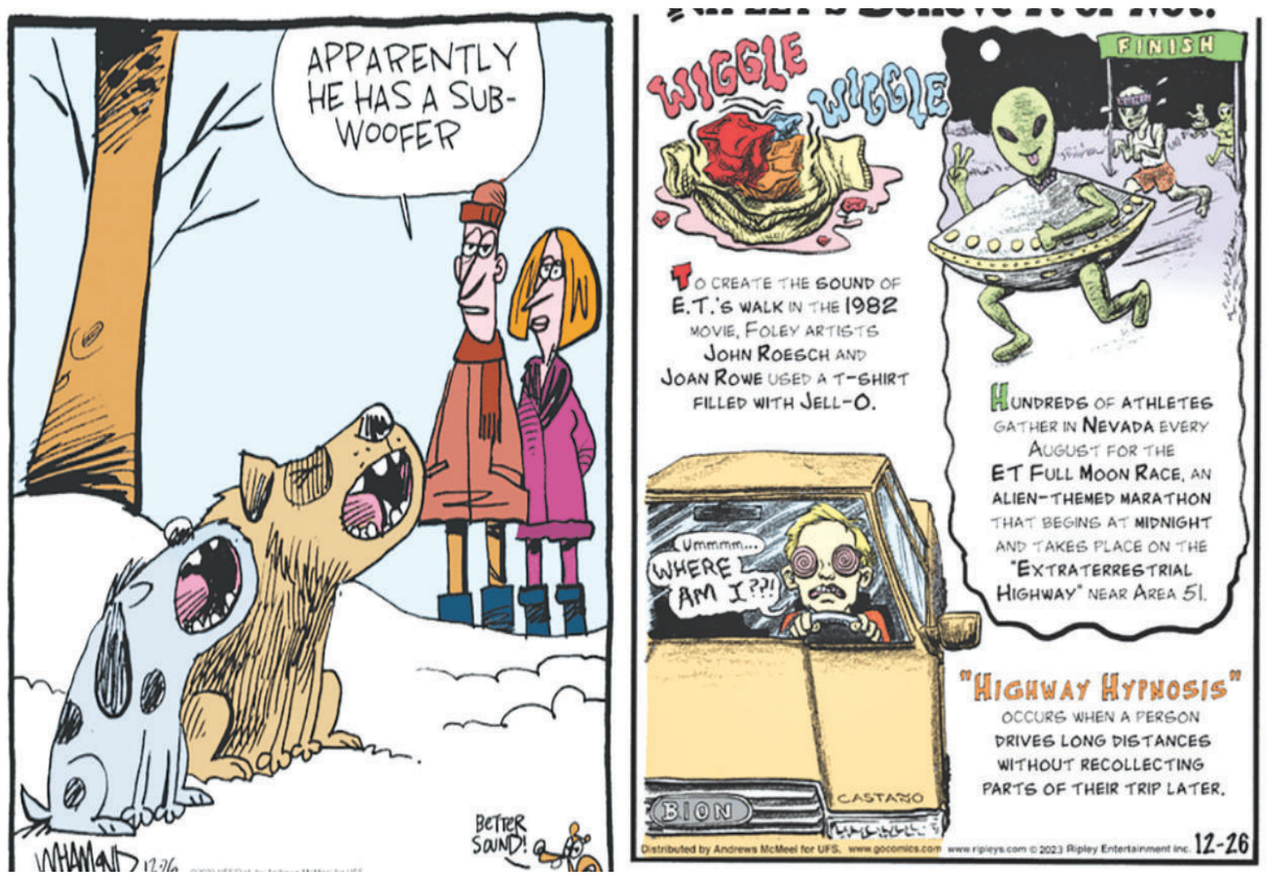
Capricorn: Your usual sense of direction may desert you without warning. It's only too understandable with fizzy Mercury and lively Mars running around together in your sleepy subconscious sector, clouding your intuition and natural judgment.

Aquarius: Popularity contests are unfortunately almost unavoidable at the moment. Everyone wants a piece of you as Mercury and Mars conjoin in your friendly 11th house. Friction arises due to Mercury Retrograde.

Pisces: You can run all you like, but the finish line seems to keep getting further and further away at this time. Satisfaction is lacking as retrograde-bound Mercury meets up with Mars in your ambitious 10th house.

CARTOON

gocomics.com



Lalitpur eliminate Kathmandu, face Pokhara in Qualifier 2

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 26

Lalitpur City Football Club (LCFC) has progressed to Qualifier 2 by defeating title-defender Kathmandu Rayzrs FC (KRFC) 3-0 in eliminator on Tuesday and kept the final hopes alive at the second season of the Nepal Super League (NSL).

Imoh Ezekiel netted a brace and Papa Ibou Kebe scored one to dump Kathmandu out of the NSL.

Lalitpur will now face Pokhara Thunders FC, which lost Qualifier 1 against Dhangadhi in penalties, on Thursday for a place in the finals being held on December 30. The winner will face Dhangadhi for the NSL Season 2 trophy.

Dhangadhi, which lost the final against Kathmandu in the first season, has consecutively booked its place in the finals.

While Anjal Shrestha, Kathmandu's goalie, kept a clean sheet against Lalitpur in the final league stage match on Saturday and booked a place in the playoffs, Lalitpur players went past him thrice on Tuesday.

However, Kathmandu, which went past Lalitpur goalie Jeffrey Baltus once to win the previous match, could not score a single goal this time.

Baltus, who played the majority of the match, was subbed out, and his and the team's clean sheet was ensured with a good save in the final minutes by substitute goalie Bishal Sunar.

Baltus now has the same number of clean sheets as top-placed Stefan Cupic of Jhapa FC. They both now have five clean sheets each.

Lalitpur started the match with pressure on Kathmandu's defence line-up with a commitment to returning the favour of the previous loss. Before the first-half whistle, Lalitpur scored past Kathmandu twice.

Imoh Ezekiel scored the first goal of the match in a commotion at the box of Kathmandu in the 36th minute.

A cross by Sanish Shrestha inside the box was cleared by Kathmandu's captain Anjan Rai, but it found Anjan's teammate creating a chance for Lalitpur's striker Papa Ibou Kebe. Kebe's shot was blocked by Anjal but only for Ezekiel to push it to the back of the net.

Kebe missed the chance in the 36th minute but did not miss to expand the lead to two goals in the 44th minute. Kathmandu's Kuldip Karki was able to make a goal-line clearance, but Kebe was there to receive the ball and score.

The second half was no different. Kathmandu was seen in pressure after Lalitpur's 2-0 lead.

The positive Lalitpur side came with the third goal, the second of the match for Imoh, in the 52nd minute. The second goal for Imoh came off a looping header on the cross by Nikhil S. Kadam in a freekick.

While there were chances for Kathmandu to score, combinations and attempts started becoming difficult after Kathmandu's captain Anjan was sent off the field with a red card after receiving his second yellow of the match in the 74th minute.

Moreover, Lalitpur missed several chances to extend the lead further after the third goal. Imoh was denied a hat trick by Kathmandu's defenders and goalie. He was adjudged the player of the match for his two goals.



PHOTO: BIKAS/TRN
Lalitpur City FC's striker Imoh Ezekiel salutes after the win against Kathmandu Rayzrs FC in the eliminator round of Nepal Super League at Dashrath Stadium, Kathmandu, Tuesday.

Labuschagne immovable as Australia frustrate Pakistan

AFP
Melbourne, Dec. 26

A stubborn Marnus Labuschagne weathered a storm to help steer Australia to 187-3 on a rain-disrupted opening day of the second Test in Melbourne Tuesday against a probing and resilient Pakistan attack.

At stumps, he was unbeaten on a glacial 44 off 120 balls and Travis Head was not out on nine after nearly three hours' play were lost to rain.

Pakistan's bowlers found plenty of movement in the overcast conditions and were rewarded with the wickets of David Warner (38), Usman Khawaja (42) and Steve Smith (26).

But a patient Labuschagne was immovable as the hosts look to seal the three-Test series after thumping the visitors by 360 runs in Perth.

Pakistan captain Shan Masood won the toss and opted to bowl first on a pitch suited to the seamers.

Spearheaded by Shaheen Shah Afridi, Pakistan bowled a good length and found early swing, with Warner dropped on two by Abdullah Shafique, who put down a regulation catch at second slip.

Warner, who made 164 in the first innings at Perth in his farewell Test series, was also fortunate to get away with an edge that sailed over the slips for a boundary on 17.

His luck ran out with a rash shot off part-time spinner Agha Salman in the final over before lunch, with Babar Azam holding a catch at slip off a thick outside edge.

Warner's long-time opening partner Khawaja has been embroiled in a dispute with the International Cricket Council over how he can bring attention to the humanitarian crisis in Gaza.

He was denied a bid to display a sticker showing a black dove holding an olive branch on his bat and instead played with the names of his daughters on his shoes.

The 37-year-old hit a boundary off the second ball he faced and looked destined for a big score before speedster Hasan Ali, back in the team after being overlooked for Perth, drew an edge that Salman took well in the slips to leave Australia on 108-2.

With dark clouds overhead, the lights were turned on mid-afternoon with Labuschagne and Smith in survival mode as the bowlers turned the screws before the rain arrived.

The conditions eventually cleared and play resumed in front of a sparse crowd, with many of the 62,000 fans giving up and going home. Smith and Labuschagne continued to play defensively, with runs hard to come by.

Labuschagne finally relieved some pressure when Aamer Jamal was brought on, hitting his first boundary in 75 balls, with the grin on his face telling a story.

It was similarly slow going for Smith, who was given out lbw on 19 after a big shout from Afridi, but a review showed the ball going high.

He was less fortunate against Jamal soon after. The umpire ignored an appeal from wicketkeeper Mohammad Rizwan for a catch, but Pakistan reviewed and it showed a faint edge, ending a 147-ball partnership.



PHOTO: AP
Australia's Marnus Labuschagne bats against Pakistan during their cricket test match in Melbourne, Tuesday.

Golden Gate, Budhanilkantha win U19 basketball title



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 26

Golden Gate and Budhanilkantha secured the titles in the boys' and girls' categories respectively at the U-19 National Basketball Tournament on Tuesday.

In the final held at the Covered Hall of the National Sports Council in Tripureshwar, Golden Gate defeated Budhanilkantha by 100-88 to secure the boy's title.

Nukesh Magar of Golden Gate was the top scorer of the match with 28 points.

In the women's title match, Budhanilkantha beat ISA Nepal by 28-18. Rinchen Moktan scored 19 points for the winning team.

The Nepal Basketball Association organised the competition in partnership with Samriddhi School.

Nukesh and Rinchen, who were also the top scorers of the final, were declared the 'Most Valuable Player' of the tournament.

A total of 20 men's and 5 women's teams participated in the competition.

SAFAL POKHARA MARATHON ON FEB 17

RSS
Gandaki, Dec 26

An international Safal Pokhara Marathon carrying a prize amount of Rs 1.85 million is going to be organised from February 17, 2024 at Pokhara of Kaski.

Ex-Sportsmen Forum Nepal is organising the Championship. Forum Treasurer Mahesh Poudel shared that the 42-kilometer open marathon would be organised towards men category.

The winner of this category would receive Rs 500,000 prize.

Similarly, half-marathon of 21 kilometer towards women category, 10-kilometer race (women-men), five kilometer race (to be participated by school students), visually impaired and wheelchair race would also be organised, he mentioned.

Race competition targeting the men and women above 50 years has been included from this year in the championship.

Forum Chairperson Hari Prasad Parajuli said study regarding the alternative route for marathon race is underway.

Surya Nepal NPGA Match Play tees off today

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 26

The second event under the Surya Nepal Golf Tour 2023-24, Surya Nepal NPGA Match Play is beginning at the Royal Nepal Golf Club on Wednesday.

The top 16 professional golfers in the Surya Nepal Golf Tour 2022-23 Order of Merit are eligible to participate in the tournament. As four pros in the top 16 have opted out of the tournament, players up to ranking 20 have been included in the first round.

Nepal No. 1 Sukra Bahadur Rai, 14th ranked Tanka Bahadur Karki, 15th ranked Bal Bhadra Rai and 16th ranked Kamal Tamang have pulled out citing personal reasons.

No 2 pro in last season's Order of Merit, Bhuwan Nagarkoti will be the top-seeded golfer in the event, while No 17 Deepak Magar, No 18 Toran Bikram Shahi, No 19 Pradeep Kumar Lama and No 20 Ram Krishna Shrestha made it to the draw.

As per the Match Play draw, Bhuwan will play against No. 20 Ram Krishna Shrestha in the first-round match. No 3 Niraj Tamang will face No 19 Pradeep Kumar Lama; defending champion and No 4 Dinesh Prajapati will take on No 18 Toran Bikram Shahi; No 5 Jayram Shrestha will face No 17 Deepak Magar.

Winners of the first matches will advance to the quarter-finals, which will be played on Thursday. The semi-final matches are slated for Friday. First-round, quarter-finals, semi-finals and third-place matches will be played over 18 holes, while the final match will be played over 36 holes on Saturday.

The tournament carries a cash purse of Rs 250,000. Eight pros who face defeats in the first round will get Rs 6,000 each, while four losing quarter-finalists will earn Rs 11,000 each. The winner of the tournament will receive Rs 60,000, while the runner-up will earn Rs 42,000.

WEATHER

Wednesday

Sunrise at 6:53 am, Sunset at 5:17 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Wednesday)

Partly cloudy in the hilly regions of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province and Gandaki Province and mainly fair in rest of the country.

Expected Temp.: 17-19 Rain Probability: 0%

Tuesday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	15.4	5.1	0.0
Dipayal	24.6	7.9	0.0
Dhangadi	25.4	9.8	0.0
Birendranagar	23.6	7.0	0.0
Nepalgunj	25.7	11.0	0.0
Jumla	17.7	-2.6	0.0
Ghorahi	23.1	9.0	0.0
Pokhara	22.4	9.5	0.0
Bhairahawa	26.5	10.7	0.0
Simara	27.4	11.4	0.0
Kathmandu	19.2	6.0	0.0
Okhaldhunga	19.2	8.5	0.0
Taplejung	17.8	7.0	0.0
Dhankuta	23.5	10.5	0.0
Biratnagar	27.7	12.2	0.0
Jomsom	15.0	-4.0	0.0*
Dharan	26.8	15.0	0.0*
Lumle	16.5	6.5	0.0*
Janakpur	30.4	12.6	0.0*
Jiri	16.2	1.2	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

December 27, 2023

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.82	Rs. 133.42
Euro	1	Rs. 146.27	Rs. 146.94
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 168.61	Rs. 169.37
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 154.92	Rs. 155.62
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 90.41	Rs. 90.82
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 100.23	Rs. 100.68
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 100.33	Rs.100.78
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.33	Rs. 9.37
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.59	Rs. 18.68
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.41	Rs. 35.57
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.44	Rs. 36.60
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.84	Rs. 3.86
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.17	Rs. 36.33
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.63	Rs. 28.76
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 10.26	Rs. 10.31
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 13.23	Rs. 13.29
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.62	Rs. 19.71
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 17.01	Rs. 17.08
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 431.95	Rs. 433.90
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 352.31	Rs. 353.90

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

Pele 'would have been sad' at state of Brazil team, says son

AFP
Sao Paulo, Dec. 26

Pele "would have been sad" at the state of the current Brazilian national team, his son Edinho has told AFP in an interview days before the first anniversary of his death on Friday.

Brazil have struggled in qualifying for the 2026 World Cup and presently occupy sixth place in the South American table, the last spot that affords direct qualification.

The Selecao have struggled without their biggest current star, Neymar, who is a long-term injury absentee after tearing knee ligaments.

"This crisis didn't appear overnight, there are big and complex problems," said Edinho, 53, who is one of Pele's seven children.

"We are experiencing a decline... we still have great players but in previous times we had more high-level players than we do today."

Edinho, who was raised by his mother as Pele and her separated shortly after they moved to New York when he signed for New York Cosmos in 1975 but grew closer to him in later life, added: "There is no doubt, if (Pele) had been there this year, he would have been very sad."

Santos, the Brazilian club where Pele spent most of his career, are also going through a tough period after they were relegated to the second division for the first time in its 111-year history.

The club is wracked by financial problems and boardroom rifts.

"Unfortunately this is no surprise. Anyone who has followed the daily life of the club could have anticipated such a scenario, and it has ended up happening," said Edinho, who was Santos' goalkeeper for several seasons.



The ceremonies to mark Friday's first anniversary of Pele's death from cancer at the age of 82 are expected to be low-key.

The six surviving children of the man widely considered the greatest footballer in history will hold a virtual meeting to mark the moment as several live in the United States, while a ceremony is scheduled to be held at the mausoleum in Santos that was opened to the public in May.

Edinho, whose life has been far from smooth serving time for money laundering and drug trafficking, said the loss of the charismatic man who scored 77 goals in 92 appearances for Brazil had left a huge hole in the family's life.

"He was exceptional, we miss him a lot," Edinho said. "He carried our country's name through football, which we are very proud of."

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THE RISING NEPAL

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Operational approach of government will be changed: Prime Minister

Govt's focus now on game-changing hydropower projects

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In his address to the nation on the completion of one year in office on Tuesday, the Prime Minister said, "Today, in this statement, I admit to the people of the nation that the government did not fail, but the outcomes did not align with my aspirations."

"I declare publicly that the government's working style will now undergo a transformation," Prime Minister Prachanda said.

He further said that besides specific predetermined and unavoidable events, he would not attend external programmes. His focus would revolve around formulating new policies, drafting programmes and budgets, and addressing developmental challenges and governance issues.

"I am restructuring the Prime Minister's Office this week, this will serve as a signal and a message for the entire state," he stated.

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During this period, 181.29 km of new track has been opened, he said, adding, "An additional 162,000 safe houses have been constructed and provided to the beneficiaries."

While this figure indicates progress compared to previous years, I am not satisfied with the outcomes, he added.

He informed that he was discussing policy and practice to ensure a minimum of two shifts in infrastructure development, aiming to align it as closely as possible to the 'barracks model'.

He said that necessary initiatives would be taken to increase production by augmenting exports.

This year, there's a 2.7 percentage point decrease in the consumer price growth rate compared to last year, he said, adding enhancing government policy and administrative capability is now his priority to further lower the inflation rate and make people realise the change. He also announced to expand the scope of health insurance.

Stating that the government was committed to ensuring effective implementation of Health Insurance Act, he pledged to enhance current insurance coverage and integrate all free programmes, excluding the fundamental ones, into a unified health insurance framework.

He further said that significant success was achieved in fostering trust in democracy by dismantling the VIP culture. Stating that previously a 'VIP culture' prevailed where high-profile individuals seemed untouchable by the law, he said, following the government's extensive investigation and action, even top-ranking officials, once deemed beyond law's reach, are now being held accountable.

Furthermore, the Prime Minister announced that political appointments in universities would come to an end and a merit-based approach would be adopted.

"Top-level meetings will now convene with the aim of enhancing universities, shaping a unified national perspective on foreign policy, fostering job creation, and enhancing the nation's image for investment, rather than solely focusing on power distribution," he added.

Qualified Nepalis residing anywhere in the world can aspire to become the Vice-Chancellor by presenting a transparent and convincing plan for university reform, he added.

"Meritocracy will now start and Tribhuvan University will be the point of departure," he added.

Prime Minister Prachanda has said that he is determined to complete the rest of the peace process with consensus.

Terming Nepal's peace process 'unique and exemplary' for the world, he stated that it has gained recognition at the international stage. "However, some tasks of the process remain to be completed. Now, I am determined to complete the rest of the peace process with consensus," he said in his address to the nation on Tuesday.

PM Prachanda said that during his foreign visits as the Prime Minister, he clearly stated the priorities, interests and issues of mutual cooperation of Nepal with the concerned countries.

"A strong and balanced relationship has been maintained with India and China. The cooperation and support of these neighbouring countries has increased in Nepal's development efforts. At the World Food Conference held in Rome, Italy, Nepal's presentation on food security and solving the problems of underdeveloped countries has drawn the world's attention," he said.

Likewise, the content presented by Nepal in the General Assembly of the United Nations and its other meetings has received international attention. According to him, the United Nations Secretary General's visit to Nepal at his invitation and Nepal's presentation at the Climate Change Conference held in Dubai last month, 'COP-28', were effective.

Similarly, Tatopani-Khasa, Rasuwa-Kerung, Hilsa-Purang and Korala border point of Mustang, which have been closed for a long time, have been opened for bilateral trade. "I raised the issue of tri-national connectivity for the second time when I was the Prime Minister and announced to build the road corridor to connect China and India. Now the work of the Mahakali Corridor is moving at a fast pace. The budget has been assured for the Dipayal-Khutia road connecting Taklakot in Tibet," said PM Prachanda.

Please scan the QR code for related video

Meanwhile, he also expressed his commitment to prove wrong the statement that the water of Melamchi will not come to Kathmandu, and said that he is working with a compact plan of 28 days with the target of delivering 170 million litres of water a day to the water treatment plants at Sundarijal within a month.

PM Prachanda also said that the minimum wage of workers in the country has been increased to Rs. 17,350. More than 950,000 people who have gone for foreign employment or are self-employed abroad, are in the informal sector or are self-employed within the country have been included in the contribution-based social security scheme.

Similarly, PM Prachanda said that the government's diligence in search and rescue operations in the aftermath of the Jajarkot earthquake has increased the trust of the people towards the state. The government has decided to provide Rs. 50,000 per family for the construction of temporary housing for the families whose houses have been damaged in the earthquake and are not fit for habitation. Rs. 2.26 billion has been disbursed for the same. The temporary reconstruction work will be completed within a month, said the Prime Minister.

"Development cannot be accelerated without democracy being strong, and its benefits cannot be equally distributed among the people. Now some people have resorted to false and misleading propaganda to create resentment towards the system," said PM Prachanda while adding that their comment that the unitary rule was better than the republication system now is completely wrong.

"I am firm in favour of strengthening the provinces. Lately, I have heard and understood the dissatisfaction of the chief ministers. I assure them through this speech today that all knots of federalism are being untied very fast," he said. "It was me who convened the first meeting of the National Coordination Council."

Today, I want to bear witness to the people and also tell the ministers that we cannot afford to fail. I am in no condition and mood to forgive anyone for poor performance, stated PM Prachanda. "If I cannot create positive change and hope in the country, there is no need for me to hold the position," he said.

He also said that he would continue to strive for dialogue and understanding with the main opposition and other political parties for the implementation of the important issues related to the execution of the constitution, and for cooperation on other issues of national importance to complete the remaining work of the peace process.

Similarly, Prime Minister 'Prachanda' has said that the government is now focusing attention on game-changing large hydropower projects.

He said that India, Bangladesh and China are ready to become partners in our electricity trade, so the government has embarked on mega hydropower projects as a game changer.

He said that the infrastructure tax levied on petroleum products for the Budhigandaki hydropower project will be made available to the same project and there will be no dearth of resources.

The Prime Minister said that further study of the Karnali Chisapani hydropower project with a capacity of 10,800 megawatts has been started by the Nepal Electricity Authority with a goal of completing it within three years.

Likewise, study of the Mugu Karnali hydropower project of 1,902 MW capacity has been completed, Prime Minister Prachanda said, adding that he is also directly facilitating the 900 MW capacity Arun III hydropower project and the work of raising investment for the 1,063 MW Upper Arun hydropower project has reached its final stage.

Stating that about 564 megawatts of electricity will be added from additional projects undergoing testing commissioning within next two to three months, he said that power purchase agreements for 9,164 megawatts of hydropower projects have been completed with the private sector.

» SEE PAGE 6



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' delivering his address to the nation on the occasion of the completion of one year of the government in Kathmandu on Tuesday.

- 2080s to be the decade of rapid development
- Announcement to widen scope of health insurance
- Peace process to be completed
- Water supply of Melamchi project to resume within a month
- Production-based subsidy system being implemented
- Tourism in thriving trend

One Year of Government Special Supplement

Today's TRN carries a supplement to mark the govt's completion of one year and its achievements.



'Nepal should benefit from neighbours' advancements'



Minister Rekha Sharma

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 26

Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma has said that Nepal should reap the benefit from the progress of neighbouring countries.

Minister Sharma made this remark while addressing the second China-Nepal Media Summit organised by the South Asia Network Television Media Group in coordination with the Chinese Embassy in Kathmandu on Tuesday.

The function was organised to mark the 10th anniversary of the Belt and Road Initiative and the 68th anniversary of the establishment of diplomatic relations between Nepal and China.

Pointing out that Nepal is happy with the economic progress made by its neighbours, Minister Sharma said that Nepal is benefiting from the development of its neighbours and it should be increased qualitatively.

"We expect important projects in Nepal to move forward with Chinese support. If projects such as the Nepal-China cross-border railway, the Kerung to Kathmandu-Lumbini railway can proceed, it could add a new dimension to Nepal's prosperity," said Minister Sharma.

Minister Sharma said that Nepal has been participating in various projects conducted by neighbouring and international communities in a way that aligns with the national interest.

» SEE PAGE 6

Efforts begin to reduce human-elephant conflict

BY BISHNU PRASAD POKHAREL
Damak, Dec. 26

Elephants coming from Assam, West Bengal and Mahanand Wildlife Sanctuary of India to Koshi Tappu Wildlife Reserve have been terrorising locals.

Considering these problems, efforts are now underway on both the Nepali and Indian sides to address the problems by protecting elephants, reducing human-elephant conflicts and promoting human-elephant coexistence.

The impetus to minimise human-animal conflict has started at a time when the elephants are prolonging their stay in Jhapa, causing more destruction.

Arjun Karki, ward chairman of Mechinagar Municipality-4, said that Kedar Karki, the Chief Minister of Koshi Province, has expressed interest in formulating effective practices for elephant control and risk reduction.

Chief Minister Karki has committed to implementing necessary programmes to control human-animal conflict within the province after inspecting the trespassing of elephants and rhinos.

A Rapid Response Team (RRT) has been established in Bahundangi to provide conservation awareness training to local youth regarding elephant behaviour and how they should treat the animals. A similar team has also been formed on the Indian side.



Ward chairman Karki said that an information network has been established to connect the RRTs on both sides of the border to share activities related to elephants. Surveillance is conducted at entry points based on information about the movement of elephants.

An 'early warning siren' has been installed at the Armed Police Force post to alert villagers about elephants entering the village. Residents are advised to stay indoors upon hearing the siren. Following the siren, the RRT, along with members of the Armed Police and the Nepal Police, jointly monitor the entry points.

Due to these efforts, there have been no recent casualties in Bahundangi, which is considered a heavily affected area in eastern Nepal, said Karki.

Bahundangi serves as a primary crossing point for elephants travelling between Nepal and India, causing long-term effects on the lives of residents. Karki added that elephants have damaged harvests, and stored grains, fruits, and cash crops.

To discourage elephants from easily entering the area, an electric fence has been installed at the border towards Nepal. However, elephants persistently use familial paths, damaging electric fences to access crops. He emphasised the need to address the concerns of affected communities and establish trust for fostering elephant-friendly human behaviour.

To assist the victims, the ward has decided to provide annual financial assistance of Rs. 12,000 to those affected by elephant attacks, particularly aiding the children of those who lost their parents in such incidents.

The team involved in this initiative is insured for Rs. 500,000, aiming to prevent potential losses of life and property caused by elephants entering the village despite vigilant monitoring of entry points.

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Qualified Nepalis residing anywhere in the world can aspire to become the Vice-Chancellor by presenting a transparent and convincing plan for university reform, he added.

"Meritocracy will now start and Tribhuvan University will be the point of departure," he added.

Prime Minister Prachanda has said that he is determined to complete the rest of the peace process with consensus.

Terming Nepal's peace process 'unique and exemplary' for the world, he stated that it has gained recognition at the international stage. "However, some tasks of the process remain to be completed. Now, I am determined to complete the rest of the peace process with consensus," he said in his address to the nation on Tuesday.

PM Prachanda said that during his foreign visits as the Prime Minister, he clearly stated the priorities, interests and issues of mutual cooperation of Nepal with the concerned countries.

"A strong and balanced relationship has been maintained with India and China. The cooperation and support of these neighbouring countries has increased in Nepal's development efforts. At the World Food Conference held in Rome, Italy, Nepal's presentation on food security and solving the problems of underdeveloped countries has drawn the world's attention," he said.

Likewise, the content presented by Nepal in the General Assembly of the United Nations and its other meetings has received international attention. According to him, the United Nations Secretary General's visit to Nepal at his invitation and Nepal's presentation at the Climate Change Conference held in Dubai last month, 'COP-28', were effective.

Similarly, Tatopani-Khasa, Rasuwa-Kerung, Hilsa-Purang and Korala border point of Mustang, which have been closed for a long time, have been opened for bilateral trade. "I raised the issue of tri-national connectivity for the second time when I was the Prime Minister and announced to build the road corridor to connect China and India. Now the work of the Mahakali Corridor is moving at a fast pace. The budget has been assured for the Dipayal-Khutia road connecting Taklakot in Tibet," said PM Prachanda.

Please scan the QR code for related video

Meanwhile, he also expressed his commitment to prove wrong the statement that the water of Melamchi will not come to Kathmandu, and said that he is working with a compact plan of 28 days with the target of delivering 170 million litres of water a day to the water treatment plants at Sundarijal within a month.

PM Prachanda also said that the minimum wage of workers in the country has been increased to Rs. 17,350. More than 950,000 people who have gone for foreign employment or are self-employed abroad, are in the informal sector or are self-employed within the country have been included in the contribution-based social security scheme.

Similarly, PM Prachanda said that the government's diligence in search and rescue operations in the aftermath of the Jajarkot earthquake has increased the trust of the people towards the state. The government has decided to provide Rs. 50,000 per family for the construction of temporary housing for the families whose houses have been damaged in the earthquake and are not fit for habitation. Rs. 2.26 billion has been disbursed for the same. The temporary reconstruction work will be completed within a month, said the Prime Minister.

"Development cannot be accelerated without democracy being strong, and its benefits cannot be equally distributed among the people. Now some people have resorted to false and misleading propaganda to create resentment towards the system," said PM Prachanda while adding that their comment that the unitary rule was better than the republication system now is completely wrong.

"I am firm in favour of strengthening the provinces. Lately, I have heard and understood the dissatisfaction of the chief ministers. I assure them through this speech today that all knots of federalism are being untied very fast," he said. "It was me who convened the first meeting of the National Coordination Council."

Today, I want to bear witness to the people and also tell the ministers that we cannot afford to fail. I am in no condition and mood to forgive anyone for poor performance, stated PM Prachanda. "If I cannot create positive change and hope in the country, there is no need for me to hold the position," he said.

He also said that he would continue to strive for dialogue and understanding with the main opposition and other political parties for the implementation of the important issues related to the execution of the constitution, and for cooperation on other issues of national importance to complete the remaining work of the peace process.

Similarly, Prime Minister 'Prachanda' has said that the government is now focusing attention on game-changing large hydropower projects.

He said that India, Bangladesh and China are ready to become partners in our electricity trade, so the government has embarked on mega hydropower projects as a game changer.

He said that the infrastructure tax levied on petroleum products for the Budhigandaki hydropower project will be made available to the same project and there will be no dearth of resources.

The Prime Minister said that further study of the Karnali Chisapani hydropower project with a capacity of 10,800 megawatts has been started by the Nepal Electricity Authority with a goal of completing it within three years.

Likewise, study of the Mugu Karnali hydropower project of 1,902 MW capacity has been completed, Prime Minister Prachanda said, adding that he is also directly facilitating the 900 MW capacity Arun III hydropower project and the work of raising investment for the 1,063 MW Upper Arun hydropower project has reached its final stage.

Stating that about 564 megawatts of electricity will be added from additional projects undergoing testing commissioning within next two to three months, he said that power purchase agreements for 9,164 megawatts of hydropower projects have been completed with the private sector.

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PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' delivering his address to the nation on the occasion of the completion of one year of the government in Kathmandu on Tuesday.

- 2080s to be the decade of rapid development
- Announcement to widen scope of health insurance
- Peace process to be completed
- Water supply of Melamchi project to resume within a month
- Production-based subsidy system being implemented
- Tourism in thriving trend

One Year of Government Special Supplement

Today's TRN carries a supplement to mark the govt's completion of one year and its achievements.



'Nepal should benefit from neighbours' advancements'



Minister Rekha Sharma

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 26

Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma has said that Nepal should reap the benefit from the progress of neighbouring countries.

Minister Sharma made this remark while addressing the second China-Nepal Media Summit organised by the South Asia Network Television Media Group in coordination with the Chinese Embassy in Kathmandu on Tuesday.

The function was organised to mark the 10th anniversary of the Belt and Road Initiative and the 68th anniversary of the establishment of diplomatic relations between Nepal and China.

Pointing out that Nepal is happy with the economic progress made by its neighbours, Minister Sharma said that Nepal is benefiting from the development of its neighbours and it should be increased qualitatively.

"We expect important projects in Nepal to move forward with Chinese support. If projects such as the Nepal-China cross-border railway, the Kerung to Kathmandu-Lumbini railway can proceed, it could add a new dimension to Nepal's prosperity," said Minister Sharma.

Minister Sharma said that Nepal has been participating in various projects conducted by neighbouring and international communities in a way that aligns with the national interest.

» SEE PAGE 6

Efforts begin to reduce human-elephant conflict

BY BISHNU PRASAD POKHAREL
Damak, Dec. 26

Elephants coming from Assam, West Bengal and Mahanand Wildlife Sanctuary of India to Koshi Tappu Wildlife Reserve have been terrorising locals.

Considering these problems, efforts are now underway on both the Nepali and Indian sides to address the problems by protecting elephants, reducing human-elephant conflicts and promoting human-elephant coexistence.

The impetus to minimise human-animal conflict has started at a time when the elephants are prolonging their stay in Jhapa, causing more destruction.

Arjun Karki, ward chairman of Mechinagar Municipality-4, said that Kedar Karki, the Chief Minister of Koshi Province, has expressed interest in formulating effective practices for elephant control and risk reduction.

Chief Minister Karki has committed to implementing necessary programmes to control human-animal conflict within the province after inspecting the trespassing of elephants and rhinos.

A Rapid Response Team (RRT) has been established in Bahundangi to provide conservation awareness training to local youth regarding elephant behaviour and how they should treat the animals. A similar team has also been formed on the Indian side.



Ward chairman Karki said that an information network has been established to connect the RRTs on both sides of the border to share activities related to elephants. Surveillance is conducted at entry points based on information about the movement of elephants.

An 'early warning siren' has been installed at the Armed Police Force post to alert villagers about elephants entering the village. Residents are advised to stay indoors upon hearing the siren. Following the siren, the RRT, along with members of the Armed Police and the Nepal Police, jointly monitor the entry points.

Due to these efforts, there have been no recent casualties in Bahundangi, which is considered a heavily affected area in eastern Nepal, said Karki.

Bahundangi serves as a primary crossing point for elephants travelling between Nepal and India, causing long-term effects on the lives of residents. Karki added that elephants have damaged harvests, and stored grains, fruits, and cash crops.

To discourage elephants from easily entering the area, an electric fence has been installed at the border towards Nepal. However, elephants persistently use familial paths, damaging electric fences to access crops. He emphasised the need to address the concerns of affected communities and establish trust for fostering elephant-friendly human behaviour.

To assist the victims, the ward has decided to provide annual financial assistance of Rs. 12,000 to those affected by elephant attacks, particularly aiding the children of those who lost their parents in such incidents.

The team involved in this initiative is insured for Rs. 500,000, aiming to prevent potential losses of life and property caused by elephants entering the village despite vigilant monitoring of entry points.

THE RISING NEPAL

risingnepaldaily.com

Road to Prosperity

One Year of Government
Special Supplement

Wednesday, December 27, 2023

Political Stability Achieved



Ritu Raj Subedi

Big shots, including former deputy prime minister, home minister and sitting secretary involved in the fake Bhutanese refugee scam, were sent to jail.

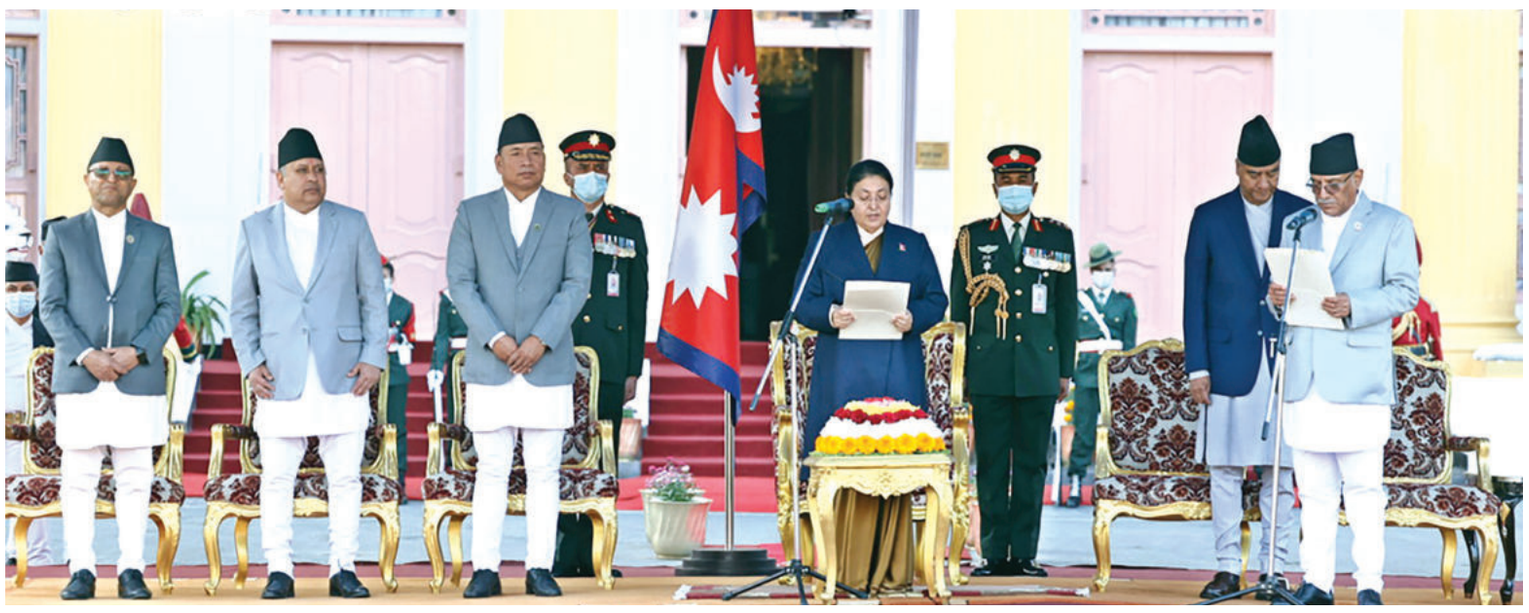
Immediately after the formation of the current coalition government, Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda had pledged to ensure stability, good governance, prosperity and effective service delivery to the public. It has so far been successful in establishing stability while making crusade against corruption that remains a key factor behind the nation's poor service delivery and economic backwardness. Economy was in a bad shape. A rumour is that the country is heading to the financial meltdown like Sri Lanka where the economic crisis took a nasty turn, forcing the sitting President to flee the country. But Nepal succeeded to avoid the economic trouble of that scale. The COVID-hit economy is out of the woods, but it is yet to attain full recovery.

Political stability is a prerequisite for economic development. A predictable order either in democratic polity or authoritarian system creates environment conducive for desired level of growth. However, the rapid economic development attained under the authoritarian regime is devoid of inclusive character and the distribution of wealth is skewed in favour of a handful of elites. In Nepal, a chronic instability has been a jinx on the inclusive growth and shared prosperity ever since it opened up and moved on the path of modernisation and democratisation in the middle of the last century. It is an irony that no government - elected or selected - completed its full term in office since 1951 when the country ushered in an era of democracy, freedom and civil liberties.

Structural shifts

The new constitution adopted in 2015 converted Nepal into a republican, secular and federal state, marking a structural shift in the political, administrative, economic and cultural spheres. Under the federal set-up, the three-tier of government came into existence. The federal polity is based on the principle of self-rule and shared rule whereby the people feel that the governments are at their disposal to resolve their problems ranging from livelihoods to health, education and social security. In 2017, the country first conducted the three-tier polls as per the new national charter. The government, formed following the historic elections, was saddled with the onerous task of consolidating the federal and republic system that is geared towards creating a socialism-oriented economy.

However, the then government of the Nepal Communist Party (NCP) that enjoyed a huge electoral mandate collapsed due to intense factionalism and conflict within the party. The House of Representatives was dissolved twice, frittering away a golden opportunity of democracy and a national-building mission.



The NCP broke into several factions. The House's dissolution shattered a dream of building a progressive and inclusive society, giving rise to disenchantment among people. This was one major reason behind the emergence of new political forces on the national scene.

A five-party coalition government came into existence to stabilise the chaotic politics. The alliance consisted of Nepali Congress (NC), CPN-Maoist Centre, CPN-Unified Socialist (CPN-US), Janata Samajabadi Party (JSP) and Rastriya Janamorcha. The current coalition formed in the aftermath of second general elections in 2022 is the continuity of the very pre-poll alliance. The composition of federal parliament has forced the parties to create coalition government as well as develop coalition culture. First and foremost, the present dispensation has restored the political stability necessary for maintaining policy consistency and securing the confidence of the bureaucracy and business community.

Nepali Congress general secretary Bishwo Prakash Sharma, while speaking in Kathmandu recently, said that no political crisis existed in the country. Democratic order has positive implications for overall performance of public and private sectors. As the coalition partners are firm to stay united till the next poll, the government is confidently moving to implement their common minimum programmes. PM Prachanda has said that he would remove underperforming ministers to expedite the development work as planned. This shows the PM's commitment to development and good governance.

Another notable gain of the government is its grit to launch investigations into various corruption scandals and forgeries. Big shots, including former deputy prime minister, home minister and sitting secretary involved in the fake Bhutanese refugee scam, were sent to jail. This bold move earned appreciation from the government. Those involved in the Lalita Niwas scam in which the government's lands were transferred into the names of private individuals were arrested. Police have nabbed individuals involved in gold smuggling that is occurring frequently.

The government and various parliamentary bodies have investigated into the sale of Ncell shares that has apparently taken place by keeping the political and business circles in dark. The government has succeeded in giving justice to the victims of loan sharks through the enactment of strict laws against the usury.

The government's zero tolerance on corruption at all levels of state aims at promoting good governance and discouraging the immoral acts in the society. There are complaints that the anti-corruption drive is being slowed down in order to 'protect' some influential politicians and let them off the hook. The government must not drag its feet and intensify the crusade to bring them to justice.

Coalition culture

The coalition government has put up a united face against the anti-systemic forces that have come to the streets, threatening to dismantle the federal, secular and republican order. This is indeed the writing on the wall, which calls for greater reform in economy, politics and delivery of public goods such as health, education and social security.

Running a coalition government is not a cake walk. It entails foreseen and unforeseen obstacles because the government has to earn trust of not only allies but also the main opposition that is intent on throwing a spanner in its works. A vibrant coalition culture is necessary to consolidate democratic republic.

Meaningful dialogue needs to be pursued to bring the extra-constitutional forces into the democratic mainstream. The government should redouble its efforts to get vital bills related to civil service, education and transitional justice approved from the House. Maintaining judicial impartiality and transparency is equally important so as to uphold the principle of justice. The government must assess one year's performance to perform better in another year.

(The author is Deputy Executive Editor of this daily.)

Economic Crisis Over, Threats Persist



Modnath Dhakal

The Nepali economy experienced an unprecedented slowdown in the last fiscal year 2022–2023, depressing all—the government, private sector, and common people. The government failed to meet the annual targets for revenue and capital budget mobilisation, and there was a gap of about Rs. 432 billion between government receipts and expenditures from the Treasury. The above 7 per cent inflation, which sustained for about one and a-half years, scared the consumers who were suffering from the reduction in increase, while a significant number of them lost their savings made at the cooperatives across the country.

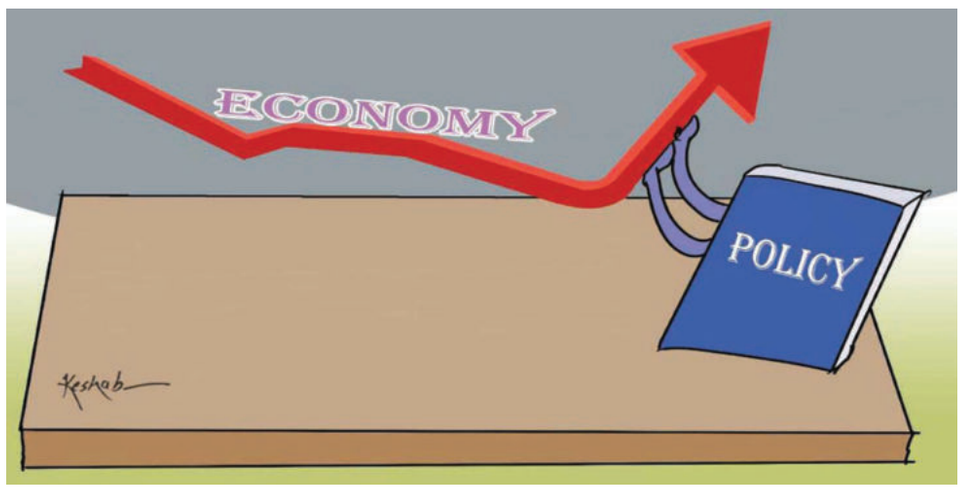
This resulted in a fall in demand in the market, which forced the private sector industries to reduce their production capacity. Most of the industries producing consumer goods were running at half of their total capacity, while decreased construction activities sent the market for construction materials to a recession, and industries like cement and steel operated at about a quarter of their installed capacity. A study conducted by the Nepal Rastra Bank (NRB) showed that the industries were utilising only 43 per cent of their capacity. Meanwhile, the government's failure to clear the dues of the private sector in time created another panic.

Although the external sector began to show improvement in the second half of the last fiscal year with measures to control impact and check the flow of foreign currency reserves out of the country, inflation hovered around 7-8 per cent scaring consumers away from the market. The government and the NRB presented the external sector improvement as an improvement in the economy, but the private sector and the public felt otherwise. At the same time, the country witnessed a record outflow of Nepali migrant workers and students.

The private sector has a view that the government as well as other parties to the national economy became apprehensive of the rapid economic expansion in the aftermath of the COVID-19 pandemic, and the government adopted a policy to reduce demand and expenses. These steps only aggravated the problem.

Good news during festivals

However, the end of the fourth month of the current FY 2023/24 has brought some good news to the economy as well as to people. Surprisingly, inflation moderated to 5.38 per cent in mid-November during the festive season, up from 7.5 per cent a month ago and 8.08 per cent a year earlier. The NRB said that the inflation of food and beverage items was 6.01 per cent and that of non-food and service products was 4.89 per cent.





Likewise, the Balance of Payments (BOP) jumped to a Rs. 147.1 billion surplus in mid-November from Rs. 20.03 billion last November. The BOP is the difference between the payments into and out of a country over a given period. The current account (difference between the country's savings and investments) remained at a surplus of Rs. 96.38 billion in the four months, against a deficit of Rs. 37.79 billion in the same period of the previous year.

The country that until mid-July last year was worried about depleting foreign exchange reserves now has Rs. 1696.8 billion in reserves, which is sufficient to cover prospective merchandise imports for 13.6 months and merchandise and services imports for 11.3 months, according to the statistics of the central bank.

Meanwhile, export trade is still struggling to regain its earlier momentum. Although the fall in exports came down to 6.09 per cent in the first five months of this year against a nose-dive of 33.33 per cent last year, the size of exports is still about Rs. 4 billion below last year's mark.

After a year in office under the leadership of Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda,' the government has successfully steered the economy towards a more favourable position.

With the correction in bank interest rates, business activities and job creation are expected to grow. Meanwhile, Prime Minister Prachanda's initiative to enhance dialogue with the private sector and increase the latter's confidence is noteworthy. He claimed that the government has gained success in maintaining the stability of the financial sector, and improvements have been seen in the investment environment.

In mid-December, the average base rate of banks came down to a single digit of 9.74 per cent from 10.6 per cent a year earlier, while the interest rates on loans moderated to 11.96 per cent from 12.65 per cent.

The government has approved a Rs. 71.25 billion investment in one year of PM Prachanda's tenure. In the meantime, the Investment Board of Nepal issued a licence for the survey for the 750-megawatt West Seti and 450-megawatt Seti River-6 hydropower projects. Progress at Arun III and other infrastructure projects is satisfactory. However, the operation of the recently built international airports in Bhairahawa and Pokhara is not satisfactory. The government has also announced plans to hold an investment summit next year to showcase the country's large projects and attract foreign investment.

Remittances continue to soar

Remittances, the backbone of the Nepali economy and the largest source of foreign currency income, continue to soar, with an increment of 26.4 per cent in the inflow of Rs. 477.96 billion. Last year, there was an increase of 20.4 per cent in remittance inflow. A couple of years ago, the country was on the verge of the Sri Lankan crisis, not having enough money to finance the import trade and service the country's loans.

However, increasing muscle and brain drain is worrisome. In the first four months of this year, the number of Nepali workers, both institutional and individual, taking first-time approval for foreign employment stands at 137,475 and taking approval for renewing entry stands at 68,841. It is less than last year's 196,735 and 87,428, respectively. Amidst the economic depression, more than 750,000 Nepalis left the country for foreign employment in 2022/23. To check the outmigration of youth and obtain their contribution to the country's growth and development, business and investment should be promoted, and more employment should be generated within the country. For this, the confidence of the private sector should be boosted through better performance at capital budget mobilisation and the execution of business-friendly policies and incentives.

At the same time, tourist arrivals by air crossed 108,600 in November, following the trend in October, a major tourist season in Nepal, when 117,306 tourists arrived here. These statistics showed that the country has gained the same momentum in tourism as before the COVID-19 pandemic.

Improved capital spending

The government's performance in utilising the budget allocated for development work has improved this year. By Saturday, December 23, this year, utilisation of the capital budget stood at 12.51 per cent (Rs. 37.7 billion) of the total allocation of Rs. 302 billion. Last year, by the same time, only 9.92 per cent of capital allocation was used; however, in terms of amount, it was the same: Rs. 37.7 billion of Rs. 380.3 billion.

Improved capital spending means better performance at development projects and more jobs for private sector businesses like construction, transportation, and human resources companies, as well as cement, iron bar, and other construction material producers. These activities help to generate employment, mobilise the market, and contribute to the economic growth of the country. Since the monsoon and festival seasons are over now, the government should put more effort into spending the development budget and expediting development and public construction.

Meanwhile, the government has to devise a strategy to increase revenue collection. The widening gap between revenue and expenditure might again repeat the situation where the government fails to pay the money to the construction companies, and development works are affected.

(The author is a journalist at The Rising Nepal)

Nepal Heading To Become Power Exporter



Laxman Kafle

Hydropower is a cheap and sustainable source of energy with negligible environmental impacts. Despite having huge potential in hydropower, Nepal has been unable to tap its resources at the desired pace.

In 112 years since the construction of the country's first ever Chandrajyoti Hydro-electric power station in Pharping in 1911, Nepal has generated only 2,800 MW power, over 75 per cent of that only in the last half-a decade.

However, the pace of hydropower development in the last one decade has significantly increased. As a result, the country that has been reeling under an 18-hour load-shedding a day, has now started exporting power to India during the rainy season. However, in a dry season, the country still has to import power to meet domestic demand.

The country added 541 MW power in the national grid in the last one year, totaling the national power production to 2,858 MW. Besides, 564 MW hydropower projects are under testing and commissioning.

The present government has given top priority to the power production, both hydro and solar, in the participation of the private sector.

Currently, the construction process of the large reservoir and semi-reservoir hydropower projects 1,200 MW Budhigandaki and 635 MW Dudh Koshi reservoir hydroelectric projects and 1,063 MW Upper Arun semi-reservoir hydropower projects are advancing.

Other hydropower projects, including 900 MW Arun III, are also in construction phase.

Access to electricity

The government and the Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA) are working to provide electricity to all citizens within one year. Now, the population with access to electricity has increased by 5 per cent and reached 98 per cent. With the improvements in electricity services, per capita energy consumption has increased to 380 units.

Grid electricity has reached 76 of 77 districts, with only Humla lacking it. Three of the seven provinces and 48 districts have been fully electrified. The Madhes, Bagmati and Gandaki provinces have been completely electrified. Similarly, around 95 per cent of electrification has been completed in Koshi Province, 98 per cent in Lumbini Province, 67 per cent in Karnali Province and 82 per cent in Sudurpaschim Province. The maximum daily electricity demand is now around 1,700 MW.

> The country that has been reeling under an 18-hour load-shedding a day, has now started exporting power to India during the rainy season.

Power export

With the progress made in the construction of hydropower projects, Nepal has started exporting power to India since last year. After the operation of 456 MW Upper Tamakoshi Hydropower, the country's largest hydropower constructed under its own investment, Nepal was able to export power to India and improve the electricity supply.

About 1.74 billion units of electricity worth Rs. 15.24 billion were exported to India in six months of rainy season this year. The export of electricity increased by 31.28 per cent this year compared to last year. So far, the NEA has received approval for the export of 657 MW electricity to the Indian market.



The government has a plan to generate about 30,000 megawatts of electricity within the next 10 years.

During Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda's visit to India in May this year, an agreement was reached between Nepal and India, according to which India will buy 10,000MW of electricity from Nepal in 10 years. This is expected to be a milestone for Nepal's hydropower development and electricity export. However, the seasonal export of power has stopped after the advent of the dry season.

Electricity export could contribute to the foreign exchange reserves while helping to narrow down the trade deficit between Nepal and India.

According to the Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA), the country will be a net exporter of energy within one year and stop the import of power to meet the national demand even during the winter season within the next two years.

This fiscal year, about 900 megawatts will be added to the national transmission system, and the NEA has expected to export electricity worth Rs. 25 billion to Rs. 30 billion next year.

In order to expand Nepal's electricity market to Bangladesh, necessary preparations have been completed to export 40 megawatts of electricity to Bangladesh in the initial phase. For this, the Government of India has already agreed, while the Government of Bangladesh has already given in-principle consent. This agreement has opened up a regional market beyond India.

Transmission lines

By adding about 500 circuit km of transmission line and substation capacity of about 2,400 MVA, the transmission line has reached about 6,000 circuit km and the capacity of the substation has reached about 9,500 MVA.

Transmission lines along various river corridors, including the Kaligandaki, Modi, Khimti, Dordi and Koshi corridors, have been completed to bring electricity generated from private sector projects to the national grid system. Construction of the Hetauda-Bharatpur-Bardghat 220 kV transmission line and Marsyangdi-Kathmandu 220 kV transmission has been completed.

Similarly, a 400 kV capacity Inaruwa substation constructed in Bhokraha Narsingh Rural Municipality-4 of Sunsari district was inaugurated on Friday. It is the second-largest substation in Nepal after the Dhalkebar substation. Construction of the third 400 kV has reached the final stage in Hetauda.The 132 kV Kushaha-Kataiya Third Circuit, Raxaul-Parwanipur Second Circuit and Mainhia-Sampatia transmission lines connecting Nepal to India have been completed and are operational, while the construction work of Butwal-Gorakhpur 400 kV cross-border transmission line has started. It has been agreed to proceed with the construction of Lamki-Bareli and Inaruwa-Purnia 400 kV transmission lines.

During PM Prachanda's visit to China, it was agreed to advance the Chilime-Kerung 220 kV transmission line connecting Nepal to China. It is expected that, with the completion of the construction of this transmission line, Nepal will also start electricity trading with China.

Challenges

Even with an increase in power generation, there is still the problem of power tripping and low voltage. It would be more challenging for the authority to improve the electricity supply. NEA has to invest billions of rupees in the construction of transmission and distribution lines.

The first challenge is the management of the market for the produced electricity. Secondly, the challenge is to increase regular and quality electricity supply.

Meanwhile, some under-construction transmission lines are affected due to delay in the permission of the Ministry of Forest to cut trees and local obstructions. There will be a disaster in the electricity sector if we are unable to complete the transmission lines which are under construction and planned in time.

The issue of carrying a river in bags has been in the news for a long time. Taking a license, holding it but not working is fatal for the country. Such practices should be scrapped, as instructed by Prime Minister Prachanda recently.

Opportunities

Nepal's water resources are not only the basis of Nepal's prosperity but also the source of green energy for South Asian countries. Currently, green hydrogen is being developed as a major source of fuel in the world. As there is a great possibility of using Nepal's water and hydropower to produce green hydrogen and ammonia and export it to the world market, the government has prepared and implemented a green hydrogen development policy. Under this, a policy has also been taken to produce chemical fertilisers necessary for food security in the future.

The hydropower could be a major source of foreign currency earnings by exporting power. The government has made and implemented an electricity consumption action plan so that the hydropower generated within the country is consumed more within the country. According to which, customs concessions on the import of electric vehicles and electric stoves, tax concessions for charging stations and incentives for the private sector to install charging stations across the country have also been provided.

At present, 51 fast charging stations have been installed by the Authority alone, while around 200 charging stations have been installed by the private sector. According to the government's policy of installing sufficient charging stations, there is an action plan to install 500 more charging stations.

The country has been spending over Rs. 350 billion annually for petroleum products, including liquefied petroleum gas. If the country substitutes the import of cooking gas by electric and uses electric vehicles, a huge amount for the consumption of petroleum products can be saved. Besides, the use of electricity will help keep the environment clean by controlling carbon evasion.

(Kafle is a journalist at The Rising Nepal.)

Addressing Nepal's Climate Vulnerability



Indira Aryal



Nepal, situated within the vulnerable Himalayan Mountain Range, is widely acknowledged as being susceptible to the effects of climate change. The June 2021 Melamchi River flood, triggered by increased northern region precipitation at the very onset of the monsoon, caused extensive loss of life and infrastructure. The August 2023 Kagbeni River flood, resulting from an upstream landslide, displaced 150 people and destroyed 29 houses. Moreover, a three-day post-monsoon rainfall in October 2021 incurred a record Rs. 8.26 billion losses, affecting 85,580 hectares of ready-to-harvest paddy crops. These events highlight Nepal's susceptibility to climate disasters, necessitating urgent adaptation measures. The nation's recurring struggles underscore the imperative to address climate issues comprehensively, acknowledging the evolving environmental threats it faces.

Global concerns

Observing the tangible impacts of climate change in Nepal's mountains and lowlands, an urgent plea has been made to the global community to halt climate-related activities and extend support to nations like Nepal, bearing the brunt of climate change despite being minor contributors to the issue.

During his visit to Nepal from 29 October 2023, UN Secretary-General Antonio Guterres also acknowledged that the mountains, essential water sources, have felt the impact of climate change.

Within this backdrop, Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' addressed COP28 summit in Dubai, emphasising the alarming rise of disasters in mountain regions and calling for immediate measures to safeguard these vulnerable landscapes.

Nepal actively participated in the COP events for many years, with the recently concluded session being deemed particularly significant. The Prime Minister addressed the global community, emphasising the urgency to address the impact of climate change, especially on developing nations like Nepal. He amply highlighted the climate crisis faced by mountainous countries.

The Dubai climate summit is taken as one of the milestones as it commenced with a landmark agreement on a loss and damage fund, aimed at assisting developing countries in dealing with the impacts of climate change.

Delegates reached this consensus on the conference's opening day, with various nations, including the host United Arab Emirates, Germany, and the United States, pledging financial support to the fund.

Since its agreement, the loss and damage fund has garnered around USD 800 million in pledges from various countries. Notable contributors include the United Arab Emirates, with a commitment of USD 100 million, the United Kingdom pledging GBP 40 million for the fund and GBP 20 million for other funding arrangements, Japan committing USD 10 million, the United States of America committing USD 17.5 million, and the European Union, including Germany, committing 225 million euros.

The fund aims to aid developing nations, especially those highly susceptibles to climate change impacts, in addressing both economic and non-economic losses associated with extreme weather events and gradual environmental changes.

Securing funds

Manjeet Dhakal, Head of the Least Developed Countries (LDC) Support Team at the Climate Analytics (CA), said that the journey to secure loss and damage funds is still a long way to go. While acknowledging the historical significance of the recent COP28 for LDCs, he added that a substantial amount of work remains to be done. Efforts need to be intensified within the country and there is necessity of further groundwork to facilitate the securing of necessary funds.

"So far, about US$800 million has been committed to the loss and damage fund." While it is a good beginning, the actual damage is expected to be in the trillions. The fund will not be distributed right away; it needs time for various stages of process and procedures. It might take up to three to four months just to set up the Board before the fund becomes operational," according to Dhakal.

Before asking for international help with loss and damage funds, there is a lot of work to be done at home, and it might take two to three years to get ready.

We need to study and plan the programmes that need funding. Getting the money will not be easy, so we should set up a body to handle the entire process and use the funds wisely.

Buddhi Poudel, Chief of the Climate Change Division under the Ministry of Forest and Environment, also agrees that getting a climate funds is not easy. We need a plan for both short and long-term funds and should provide study based scientific proof and assessments to claim the right amount.

The government is currently examining programmes and figuring out how to access climate funds through its mechanisms. To secure the funds, scientific evidence is crucial, prompting the government to plan involvement with the scientific community.

Towards net zero

Nepal had submitted its second Nationally Determined Contribution (NDC) at COP26 for the period 2021-2030 under the Paris Agreement, underscoring a dual focus on adaptation and mitigation strategies. With a distinctive emphasis on adaptation, Nepal's NDC reflects the nation's climate priorities. Key priorities include expanding clean energy generation ranging from 1,400 MW to 15,000 MW by 2030, with 5 to 10 per cent from mini and micro-hydro plants, solar, wind, and bio-energy. The unconditional target is set at 5,000 MW, and the aim is to meet 15 per cent of total energy demand through clean energy sources.

In the transport sector, ambitious goals include achieving 25 per cent sales of electric vehicles (EVs) for private passenger vehicles and 20 per cent for public passenger vehicles by 2025. By 2030, the plan is to cover 90 per cent of private passenger vehicle sales and 60 per cent of public passenger vehicle sales with e-vehicles, reducing fossil fuel dependency and emissions significantly.

Other objectives include the development of a 200 km electric rail network, promoting the use of electric stoves in 25 per cent of households by 2030, and installing 500,000 improved cookstoves by 2025. The government also aims to establish 200,000 household biogas plants and 500 large-scale biogas plants by 2025, while maintaining 45 per cent forest cover by 2030, supported by funding from REDD+ initiatives.

Additionally, Nepal has formulated the Nepal National Adaptation Plan (2021-2050), a pivotal framework integrating climate adaptation across government sectors. Aligned with the Second NDC, this plan addresses short medium and long-term goals, enhancing resilience and mitigating vulnerabilities in development planning while meeting Nepal's obligations under the Paris Agreement and the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC).

(Aryal is a journalist at The Rising Nepal.)

A Year Of The Government

Milestones In Nepal's Global Standing



Nanda Lal Tiwari

Talking about something is easy, but getting someone to listen and respond is challenging. This applies to both personal and international communication. Countries interact with each other, and some excel at making others listen, while some struggle to draw attention.

Analyzing Nepal's international engagement in prestigious summits and global meetings throughout the year, it's evident that the country achieved significant milestones in its global standing. Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' began his third term on December 26, 2022. As the Prachanda government completes its first year, it stands as a highly successful period marked by notable diplomatic achievements for Nepal.

Guterres visit

At the invitation of Prime Minister Prachanda, UN Secretary-General Antonio Guterres had a four-day official visit to Nepal starting from October 29, 2023. During his official trip, the UNSG visited Mt. Everest Base Camp and Mt. Annapurna Base Camp to highlight the consequences of climate crisis on the Himalayas, and Lumbini, the birthplace of Gautam Buddha, for the message of peace and compassion. In addition to meetings in Kathmandu, he also visited Pokhara, a beautiful tourist destination in the country.

'Today from the base of Mt Everest, I saw for myself the terrible impact of the climate crisis on the Himalayas.' As temperatures rise, glacier melt increases - threatening the lives and livelihoods of entire communities. '#Climate Action can't wait.' Guterres wrote on X (twitter), on October 30.

On October 31, Secretary-General Guterres lauded Nepal as a leading example of Climate Action and called on the international community for full solidarity with Nepal, which is responding to issues raised by Nepal. "I want to express my deep gratitude for the wonderful hospitality I enjoyed from the government & people of Nepal." As a leading example of #ClimateAction & the second largest contribution to @UNPeacekeeping, Nepal deserves the full solidarity of the international community, Guterres wrote on X.

For Nepal, Guterres' visit was itself an important event as the country attracted global attention. More important was the way the Secretary General lobbied for Nepal with regard to issues related to climate change and its terrible impact on Nepal, a Himalayan country. The visit was no less important in terms of Nepal's global publicity for the promotion of tourism. Moreover, the way Guterres showed interest in the remaining tasks of Nepal's peace process, especially transitional justice issues, and urged the political leaders to come together to settle them, also supported Nepal's organic peace process and the Prachanda government's efforts for completing the remaining peace process tasks by means of the truth and reconciliation commission and the commission on the disappeared person.

By hosting the official visit of the chief of the global body and garnering his support for Nepal's climate change issues, the Prachanda government added a milestone in Nepal's global status. It is to be noted here that the UN Secretary-General's Nepal visit took place just before a month of the 28th session of the Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC COP 28) held in Dubai, the UAE, on 30 November-12 December 2023.

COP 28

One of the most important outcomes of COP 28 for Nepal has been the acceptance of Himalayan or mountain issues with regard to climate change. Home to most of the Himalayas, the highest mountain range in the world, Nepal also houses eight out of the 14 highest peaks above 800 metres. Mountain issues have been mentioned in five different places in the key final document adopted by COP 28, the 'global stocktake,' an assessment of progress since the 2015 Paris Agreement. In points 55 and 56 under the Adaption section, the document mentions about mountains.

As the lead UN agency on mountain issues, FAO has termed COP 28 as 'A historic COP for mountains.' The UN agency has also credited Nepal's role in 'mountains' for prominent inclusion in the first global stocktake', particularly mentioning the roundtable titled "Call of the mountains: who saves us from the climate crisis?" hosted by the Prime Minister Prachanda on December 2. The round table was attended by United Nations Secretary-General António Guterres, FAO Director-General QU Dongyu, Prime Minister of Andorra Xavier Espot Zamora, and Kyrgyzstan Foreign Affairs Minister Jeenbek Kulubayev, among other high-level delegates.

The outcomes of the global climate summit, COP 28, should be seen in the light of the efforts Nepal made as a mountainous country, the way the Prachanda government hosted UNSG's visit and the issues it raised all along in the run up to the summit. Whether during his visit to Italy to participate in the United Nations Food Systems Summit+2 Stocktaking Moment (UNFSS+2) in July or in his address to the UN General Assembly in September, PM Prachanda kept raising issues of protection of mountains and that Nepal



"suffers unfairly" from climate crisis.

In his address to COP 28, PM Prachanda made it a point that Nepal was suffering from climate injustice as Nepal is bearing a direct, disproportionate, and damaging effect of climate change despite near zero contribution to global emissions. Calling upon the developed countries to fulfill their pledges, PM Prachanda said, "The loss and damage Fund must be predictable, simplified, and adequate for LDCs and mountainous countries."

If we see point 75 with the topic of finance, under the heading of Means of Adaptation and Support, of the document, we can find that Nepal was listened to in COP 28. The document emphasises the ongoing challenges faced by many developing country Parties in accessing climate finance and encourages further efforts, including by the operating entities of the Financial Mechanism, to simplify access to such finance, in particular for those developing country Parties that have significant capacity constraints, such as the least developed countries and small island developing States.

Agreement with India

Although PM Prachanda's visit to India in May this year was marred with murrah buffalo bulls in Nepal, particularly in the parliament as the main opposition CPN (UML) tried to belittle the visit as something without concrete outcomes, the agreement about increasing power trade by 10,000 MW a year within a decade was a good achievement for Nepal. Even the materialization of the gift of the murrah buffalo bulls was no less important as Nepal had long ago made such an appeal to India. During the visit, seven agreements and MoUs were signed between the two neighbours while six projects funded by India in Nepal were inaugurated. The visit remained important also because India agreed to provide a route for Nepal to export power to Bangladesh.

Power Trade Pact

During the UNFSS+2 summit in Italy in July, PM Prachanda held a meeting with Prime Minister of Bangladesh Sheikh Hasina Wazed. It is understandable that the meeting was focused on materializing the power trade between Nepal and Bangladesh, in the light that Bangladesh has been showing its interest to purchase power from Nepal and that India has agreed to provide the route through its territory. There has been a lot of talk about Nepal exporting power to Bangladesh, but the talk is yet to be translated into action. The way he talked with Indian PM Narendra Modi and held discussions with Bangladeshi PM Sheikh Hasina, PM Prachanda seemed focused on materialising a trilateral pact on power trade so that Nepal can export power to Bangladesh through the Indian route. It is hoped that PM Prachanda's personal political approach and efforts for this will soon bear a concrete fruit diplomatically and economically. It should be noted here that a good political understanding plays a key role in many economic cooperations.

BRI project with China

One of the most important agreements reached between Nepal and China during PM Prachanda's visit to the northern neighbour in September is the agreement to finalise the investment modalities for the BRI projects in Nepal. Although Nepal signed the BRI framework with China in 2017, no official BRI projects have been implemented in Nepal. It is a fact that Nepal needs foreign financial assistance, be it loan or grant, for its development. And it is an irony that Nepal is yet to implement a single BRI project with Chinese investment even after six years of the signing of the agreement. Many countries have benefited from BRI projects, but Nepal, despite being adjacent to China, the second largest economy, has lagged in attracting any BRI projects. In this light, it is an outcome of the visit that soon Nepal and China will decide on the modality of investment for BRI projects in Nepal, that is, of the projects agreed to be implemented under the BRI, agreement will be made as to which projects will be implemented with Chinese grant, which with loan and which with loan and grant combined.

Rescue from Israel

The government deserves kudos for the prompt rescue of Nepalis from Israel in the wake of the Hamas attack in Israel on October 7. In the words of PM Prachanda, Nepal is one of the first countries to rescue its nationals from that country. Over 200 Nepalis who wanted to return home following the attack were brought home within a few days. Understandably, it was possible only due to the proper diplomatic dealing of the government. Although a Nepali student, Bipin Joshi, is still kept as a hostage by the Hamas in Palestine, the government is making relentless efforts to free him, and it is hoped that the government's diplomatic maneuvers including the visits of Foreign Minister NP Saud to Qatar for the purpose will bear fruit soon.

(Tiwari is a sub-editor of this daily and the coordinator of its online edition, risingnepaldaily.com.)

Significant Progress Made In Healthcare



Ajita Rijal

> The Government is making headway in integrating social health security programmes into health insurance initiatives. The establishment of Social Service Units (SSUs) in all hospitals aims to enhance the social health protection network, ensuring a safety net for citizens across the country.

Nepal, based on Article 35 of the constitution, has recognised the "Right to Health" as a fundamental right, ensuring citizens' access to basic healthcare services. Despite commendable progress in the past two decades, challenges persist in achieving universal coverage and meeting SDG targets by 2030. The healthcare sector, which has faced significant challenges due to the COVID-19 pandemic , is now witnessing positive developments under the leadership of Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda'.

Over the past year, Nepal has witnessed notable improvements in major health sector indicators, showcasing the government's strategic decisions and initiatives. Key healthcare institutions like Bharatpur and Bheri Hospitals have transitioned into regional hospitals under the National Institute of Medical Science, signifying a commitment to strengthening healthcare services at both local and national levels. The promotion of the Tilganga Eye Institute to a World University underscores the government's dedication to advancing medical education, particularly in ophthalmology. Collaborating with Nepal Pharmacy Limited to domestically produce 18 essential medicines reflects a substantial stride towards pharmaceutical self-reliance, ensuring a stable supply for all citizens.

Global recognition of Dr. Ruit

The global recognition of Dr. Sanduk Ruit by the Bahrain government and the ISA Award for Service to Humanity attest to the calibre of healthcare professionals in Nepal, highlighting the country's global healthcare expertise. The proposed scholarship bill for health science institutes underscores a commitment to nurturing the next generation of healthcare professionals, emphasising the significance of investing in education and training for a resilient healthcare workforce. Infrastructure development has been a focal point, with the government completing the construction of basic hospitals at 655 local levels. This widespread effort aims to bring healthcare closer to communities, ensuring even remote areas have access to essential services. Technological advancements, such as the O.P.D. registration system and a healthcare records app, enhance efficiency and improve overall patient records by offering timely and accessible services.

The provision of free health services for both general and economically disadvantaged citizens in federal and provincial hospitals reflects inclusivity, overcomes healthcare disparities, and ensures accessibility. This initiative supports the overarching goal of achieving universal healthcare coverage and promoting a more equitable distribution of health resources.

As the government continues its positive trajectory in the health sector, several transformative initiatives are shaping the future of healthcare in the country. They include legal safeguards, social health integration, vaccination drives, elderly care



focus, and preventive healthcare measures. Recognising the importance of a robust legal framework, the government is actively strengthening its legal system to ensure the safety of health institutions, doctors, and health workers.

The Amendments to the Safety of Health Workers and Health Institutions Act, 2022, are underway, providing a protective shield for those on the frontlines of healthcare. This legal safeguard is crucial for fostering a secure environment for healthcare professionals and ensuring the continuity of essential health services. The Government is making headway in integrating social health security programmes into health insurance initiatives. The establishment of Social Service Units (SSUs) in all hospitals aims to enhance the social health protection network, ensuring a safety net for citizens across the country. This integration is a critical step towards creating a comprehensive healthcare system that addresses not only immediate healthcare needs but also provides long-term financial security.

As a commitment to seniors, specialised health services are being developed. Initiatives include the development of the Geriatric Health Services Strategy and Senior Citizens Health Services Operation Standards. The groundwork for specialized health services for the elderly is being laid, with an interoperability framework and telemedicine services in operation. This focus on elderly care acknowledges the changing demographics of the population and aims to provide tailored healthcare services that address the unique needs of the elderly. The prepared proposal for the organisation and management survey of 500-bed hospitals is currently under discussion with various ministries and stakeholders. An agreement process has been initiated to provide free access to 35 types of medicines for cancer treatment in children. The construction of laboratories is underway in seven provinces.

The App system for O.P.D. registration for insured individuals in some federal hospitals and institutions has been implemented. Additionally, an app has been introduced to keep records of lab reports, eliminating the need to stand in long lines. During the past year, free general health check-ups and treatments have been made available to 3,523 impoverished and vulnerable citizens in federal and provincial hospitals. Satellite clinics have been established at five institutions and seven federal hospitals. In collaboration with local authorities, 300 centres have conducted civic health campaigns.

Free health services

According to the Ministry of Health and Population (MoHP), 10 per cent of total beds in government hospitals are reserved for impoverished, helpless, and disabled patients, and information about this is publicly available. The system includes displaying information on notice boards and electronic boards. To bolster cancer diagnostics and treatment, the government is set to purchase a Pet Scan Machine and a Cyclotron Production Machine. However, the logistical challenges, particularly the lack of space for installation, are being addressed. The focus on cancer extends to launching a vaccination programme against cervical cancer, with significant progress in screening initiatives. This comprehensive approach to cancer care addresses both prevention and treatment.

The vision for the Shaheed Dharmabhakta National Transplantation Centre is taking shape, aiming to produce specialists in organ transplantation. Free kidney transplant services for the economically challenged are underway, with 321 kidney patients benefiting from this initiative. This initiative not only addresses a critical healthcare need but also promotes inclusivity by ensuring that life-saving treatments are accessible to all segments of the population. By collaborating with health science academies and medical colleges, the government is promoting community engagement through free health camps. These camps, conducted twice a year, facilitate the exchange of health technology and experiences.

Additionally, various institutions, like the National Academy of Medical Sciences and B.P. Koirala IHS, are providing free health services, contributing to healthcare accessibility. The establishment of laboratories in provinces and ongoing discussions on medical research within the Ministry of Law, Justice, and Parliamentary Affairs show a commitment to advancing research and diagnostic capabilities. This decentralised approach is crucial for ensuring that healthcare services are accessible and tailored to the specific needs of different regions.

While acknowledging these positive developments, it is imperative to address systemic issues such as corruption, anomalies, and shortages of infrastructure, medical equipment, the workforce, and essential medicines. These achievements are expected to greatly improve the overall health and enhance the well-being of the people. The government's dedication to ongoing improvements and transformative strategies positions Nepal's healthcare system for continued success in meeting the evolving healthcare needs of its population.

(Rijal is a journalist at The Rising Nepal)

Government Boosts Sports Priority



Pramod Joshi



Nepal has emerged as a formidable contender in international cricket, garnering global attention with its stellar performances in 2023. This year has been particularly noteworthy for Nepali sports, with cricket taking centre stage and the nation achieving remarkable milestones, including rewriting T20I World records and securing a spot in the T20 World Cup.

Nepal's journey to the T20 World Cup 2024 was sealed with an impressive performance in the ICC Men's T20 World Cup Asia Region Qualifier held in Kathmandu.

As a result, fervent Nepali sports enthusiasts eagerly anticipate witnessing their team compete on the world stage for the second time, following their appearance in 2014.

The Hangzhou Asian Games witnessed Nepal's cricket team shattering multiple world records, captivating the global cricketing community, and solidifying its presence on the international stage.

Furthermore, the team's exceptional performance in the ICC Cricket World Cup League 2, progressing from the second-last spot to an automatic berth in the Zimbabwe ICC Men's Cricket World Cup Qualifier, underscores the newfound strength of Nepali cricket.

While narrowly missing qualification for the 2023 ICC ODI Cricket World Cup, Nepal made a significant impact in the 2023 ODI Asia Cup. Impressively competing against cricket powerhouses India and Pakistan during the Asia Cup, as well as showing resilience against Test-playing nations West Indies, Zimbabwe, and Ireland during the ODI global qualifier, Nepal showcased its prowess and potential.

The success story extends to the Under-19 national cricket team, which has also qualified for the World Cup scheduled to be held in South Africa next year.

Cricket momentum

To sustain and elevate this momentum in Nepali cricket, the government recognises the necessity for match exposure against experienced teams, necessitating significant structural and infrastructural changes in Nepali sports.

Acknowledging this success, the Nepal government, under the leadership of Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal, has made a commendable decision to prioritise sports as a crucial component of its national agenda.

Prime Minister Dahal, expressing a strong commitment to the development of the sports sector, has consistently assured government support for the advancement of Nepali sports.

The head of government firmly believes that the progress of sports is linked to the prosperity of the country. He is confident that Nepal has the potential to make significant strides in sports, provided that they give proper attention to producing athletes, developing physical infrastructure, and promoting sportspeople.

The government's focus extends to the development of sports infrastructure, emphasising investments in modern facilities, training academies, and state-of-the-art stadiums.

To ensure widespread access to sports, the government has guaranteed budgets for the construction of sports units and grounds in each of the country's 171 municipalities.

The government under Dahal has given high priority to the construction of cricket stadiums, allocating a significant budget for this purpose.

The aim is to complete major cricket stadiums such as Mulpani Cricket Stadium in Kathmandu, Girija Prasad Koirala Stadium in Biratnagar, Dashrath Chand in Baitadi, Fapla Cricket Stadium in Kailali, and Subarna Shumsher Cricket Stadium in Kathmandu.

Despite these positive steps, challenges such as delays in stadium construction, bureaucratic hurdles, and legal issues have been encountered.



The Prime Minister's directive to install floodlights at the TU Cricket Ground, following Nepal's exceptional performance in WCL 2, faced delays due to bureaucratic processes. However, progress is underway, with the evaluation of tenders completed and the intent to install floodlights imminent.

Efforts are being directed towards completing highly prioritised projects, including the Mulpani Cricket Stadium, Girija Prasad Koirala Stadium, and others.

Work on the highly prioritised Mulpani Cricket Stadium is underway, with 37.25 per cent of the project already completed. Currently, the focus is on constructing the VIP pavilion. Additionally, the government has initiated field preparation for the Mahendranagar Cricket Stadium.

During the first year of Prime Minister Dahal, the preliminary design for the Girija Prasad Koirala Cricket Stadium was completed.

The construction of the parapet for the VIP pavilion at Pokhara Cricket Stadium and the regular parapet at Bhairahawa Cricket Ground is currently underway. Additionally, the construction of the Women Cricket Academy in Kohalpur, Banke, is progressing well, with ten per cent of the work completed this year.

Training, awards

The government's commitment to sports extends beyond infrastructure, with investments in athlete training, awards, and welfare. More than 10,000 sportspersons have received national-level training, and financial support has been provided to players achieving success on the international stage.

Regular training sessions were provided to 155,000 players. Athletes were also given opportunities for foreign training in preparation for the Guangzhou Asian Games. During the Asiad, Nepal received one silver medal in karate from Arika Gurung and one bronze medal in women's kabaddi. Palesha Goverdhan won Nepal's first medal at the Para-Asian Games held in Guangzhou in para-taekwondo.

The government's proactive stance includes awards for outstanding achievements, monthly allowances for medal-winning athletes, and the formulation of a sports insurance policy.

Prime Minister Dahal has been swift in announcing cash awards to provide timely motivation to players. Under his administration, new regulations for awards have been formulated, and despite some delays, the government has fulfilled its commitment by disbursing the promised cash awards to deserving athletes.

The government has recognised and rewarded the national cricket team for their triumph in the ACC Men's Premier Cup and their qualification for the global qualifiers of the ICC Men's ODI World Cup. Each member of the national cricket team has received a cash reward of Rs. 700,000 from the government.

Furthermore, the government has maintained its commitment to supporting athletes by continuing the provision of monthly allowances to South Asian Games gold medalists, Asian Games medalists, and Olympians.

The recent introduction of the sports insurance policy demonstrates the government's dedication to the welfare of athletes, providing much-needed security for players and event organisers alike.

As Nepal continues its journey towards sporting excellence, the government's unwavering support is poised to propel the nation to even greater heights on the global stage.

(Joshi is Associate Editor at TRN)

Appreciable Achievements In ICT



Kishor Basyal

> Today the Government Cloud hosts 337 government agencies and operate 807 virtual machines. In essence, cloud computing empowers governments to operate more efficiently, securely manage data, enhance service delivery, and adapt quickly to changing needs, ultimately contributing to better governance.





Nepal is experiencing major changes brought about by the widespread adoption of digital technologies. As the digitalisation of public services takes hold in local, provincial, and federal levels, all Nepali people - regardless of their location, identity or social status - are getting faster, more economical and effective services with every passing day. And underpinning this revolution is information communication technology (ICT). Today, a vast majority of services, from applying for driving license to making property-related transactions, have moved online. Several hospitals, including Karnali Provincial Hospital in Surkhet, have launched online booking system for patients to register, make appointments to see doctor of their choice on their preferred date, among other services. As the government doubles down on its effort to make these crucial technologies even more accessible in remote corners of the country and integrate them into e-governance, public services are expected to get even better. During the past year, there have been notable works in this sector, accelerating the pace of digitisation.

Achievements

ICT has played a crucial role in enhancing e-governance, facilitating easy access to government services and information for citizens. Through online portals, they can access various government services anywhere and anytime and without requiring them to be physically present. ICT tools, like Nagarik App and other social media platforms and online forums, have enabled the three-tier governments to engage with citizens, collect feedback and incorporate them in decision making processes, increasing people's participation in governance. Not only has this given voice to the voiceless but has also empowered them to have their say in the decisions that affect them.

Five new public services have been added to Nagarik App, including the driving license, taking the total to 62. IT has also aided in the collection, storage, and analysis of vast amounts of data, which in turn has helped government agencies make informed policy decisions and optimise resource allocation. This has also reduced paperwork, administrative costs, and processing time, leading to cost savings for both governments and service-seekers, and enabling the former to be more responsive to the needs, concerns and demands of the latter.

Adoption of cloud computing has made matters even sweeter. When government agencies operate their systems through their own infrastructures, the cost of human resource management and infrastructure will increase, so the concept of creating a shared infrastructure of the Government Cloud has been introduced for maximum use at the minimum cost.

The necessary resources (CPU, RAM, Storage, Public IP, among others) are provided to Nepal government agencies to host and operate websites and web applications, backup important data, and operate information technology related systems. Through this technology, resources are provided as free virtual computer equipment from a common platform prepared by connecting server, storage, network device, security device and other computer equipment.

Today the Government Cloud hosts 337 government agencies and operate 807 virtual machines. In essence, cloud computing empowers governments to operate more efficiently, securely manage data, enhance service delivery, and adapt quickly to changing needs, ultimately contributing to better governance. The result is clear for all to see government machineries have become more transparent, leaving little or no space for corruption to rear its ugly head.

ICT when coupled with internet empowers the former to a whole new level. It is via the internet these tools deliver their services. The internet's global nature ensures that ICT solutions, services, and information are accessible globally, providing the infrastructure and connectivity needed for these tools to function.

And optical fibre has so far been the most important medium for the internet to transmit high-bandwidth data at lightning speed over a long distance in the most reliable way. It forms the backbone of internet infrastructure, connecting internet service providers (ISPs) to the users and all other computer networks. This past year, the government has been able to expand the optical fibre based FTTH (Fibre to the Home) to the remote districts of Taplegunj, Bajhang, Bajura, West Rukum, Jumla, and Kaliot, bringing the total number of districts with such facility from 67 to 73 and its length from 12230 to 15000 kms. This has laid the groundwork for the density of internet users to reach 134.76 per cent from 131.5 per cent over the period.

In the same vein, the expansion of 4G/LTE has grown from 63.81 per cent to 67 per cent. Trial works to launch 5G has also been initiated. To track the lost cell phone, the Online Tracking System (MDMS) has been brought into operation. Broadband internet has been installed in all local level offices, 10,146 community schools, and 4,390 health centres. Distribution of very high-speed internet (1 Gbps) based on XGPON technology has been started. In an effort to preserve Gorkhapatra Corporation as the national heritage, digital archiving of its publications right from its founding year 1958 is in the works, with 1655 audio contents of Radio Nepal already being digitised and archived.

Future course

The nature of technology is such that it upgrades rapidly, meaning that newer updated version of the technology currently in use has already been rolled out. So, staying complacent can never be an option. Artificial Intelligence (AI) has taken the world by storm, bringing and promising revolutionary changes.

To stay relevant and avoid the risk of falling behind, adoption of AI-powered tools in critical sectors is imperative. One such sector is weather forecasting. Nepal is a country highly prone to natural hazards, with floods, landslides, wildfires and other natural disasters claiming hundreds of lives and destroying or damaging properties worth billions every year.

Many countries, including India, are making use of AI to build climate models to improve weather forecasting as extreme weather events get increasingly devastating.

AI is so appealing because it has already outperformed conventional forecasting models in precision and cost. That means it can generate higher quality data at lower cost, obviating the need for costly super computers presently in use. Accurately forecasting devastating natural hazards like drought, floods, and heat waves means saving lives and properties in the event of their arrival. So, the country cannot afford to remain a laggard in developing and harnessing the power of AI. Steps must be taken towards this direction.

(Basyal is a journalist at The Rising Nepal.)